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THE ORIGINALITY AND INFLUENCE OF JOACHIM OF FIORE

By MARJORIE REEVES

I

Originality and influence are obverse and reverse of one coin. When extensive influence is claimed for any thinker the question at once arises: Were there no other sources from which these putative disciples might have drawn their inspiration? Since no thinker springs entirely unheralded out of the head of Zeus, he must have drawn on an already existing cluster of ideas and therefore, in turn, his possible influence may merge into a wider intellectual ambience. The problem of influence thus becomes one of establishing marks of originality which can be applied as a kind of 'litmus test' to distinguish direct dependence from general affinity. The ideas of the Abbot Joachim have lately attracted wide-ranging claims in respect of their influence in later generations. To cite only one example: Professor Roger Garaudy is quoted as saying that the 'first great revolutionary movements in Europe' were 'all more or less imbued with the ideas of Joachim of Fiore.'¹ In the last decade or so many medievalists, including myself, have spun the Joachimist coin in order to turn up 'tails,' and we have perhaps found Joachimist 'tails' in too many quarters. By the law of probabilities it was more than time to turn up heads, and Robert Lerner in an article of 1976² slapped down a challenging 'head study' for which I personally am grateful since it set me off spinning the same old coin again. The purpose of this study, therefore, is to examine the background of ideas out of which Joachim's theology of history was generated, to pinpoint the original aspects of his thought, if any, and thence to define and apply criteria for claiming later individuals, groups, or writings as 'Joachite' or 'Joachimist.'

To go back to its very root-tip: Joachim's vision of history sprang, of course, from the Judaeo-Christian concept of history as lineal, not cyclical, running from the beginning of time to its end under the rule of God, who had created time and would ultimately wind it up. This is not to say that a cyclical element was entirely absent. Like other ancient peoples the Hebrews kept the cycle of religious festivals which grew directly out of the physical cycle of the seasons.

¹ R. Garaudy, 'Faith and Revolution,' *Ecumenical Review* 25 (1973) 66.

² R. Lerner, 'Refreshment of the Saints: The Time after Antichrist as a Station for Earthly Progress in Medieval Thought,' *Traditio* 32 (1976) 97-144.

But, as Robert Hanning observes, 'those elements of the ritual observance of the Jews which manifested a timeless or semicyclical pattern were kept within the living context of the historically-centered prophetic tradition.'³ From this source the Christian Church derived its cycle of the liturgical year, and it is worth noting here that in his spiral figure of the *Mysterium ecclesiae*⁴ Joachim combined precisely the annually returning order of the Church's liturgy with the onward march of history towards its final Pentecost. Thus, in its main thrust, both Jews and Christians saw history as moving in one direction to a definite 'end.' The time process derived its meaning from the fact that through it God revealed Himself to men. The nature of His providential ordering of the world from start to finish was disclosed in the Scriptures, and, through this, man was shown the road to his salvation. The Hebrew prophetic tradition focused attention on God's specific operations in history and from this was derived a sense of the importance of particular happenings and particular human choices. Onto the Hebrew prophetic expectation of the future, Christians grafted the ideas of prophecy fulfilled in the First Advent of Christ and of prophecy to be consummated in the Second Advent still to come. And here the early Christian imagination began to develop its typological method, seeing God's revelation of Himself to the patriarchs and prophets of the Old Testament as foreshadowing His complete self-disclosure in the life and words of Jesus. This emphasis on types and fulfillments has a twofold significance: it stamps with eternal meaning certain particularities of history, and it implies a sense of divinely ordained progress within history.

The next essential step was to extend the range of God's operation in history beyond the 'salvation history' covered in the two Testaments. So long as Christians stood outside the secular order or were actively persecuted by it, secular history had little meaning, except as a manifestation of Satan. But the recognition of the Church by Constantine necessitated a new effort of the imagination. To quote Hanning again: 'the expansion of the historical imagination of Christianity beyond the confines of biblical history to include universal history within its understanding of God's unfolding providence depended upon discovering a way to include Rome directly within the divine plan for man.'⁵ Robert Hanning and Theodore Mommsen⁶ have traced the various factors which contributed to the developing Christian view in the fourth century that the Roman Empire formed part of God's plan in ordering history.

³ R. Hanning, *The Vision of History in Early Britain* (New York 1966) 6.

⁴ *Il Libro delle Figure dell' Abate Gioachino da Fiore II*, edd. L. Tondelli, M. Reeves, and B. Hirsch-Reich (Turin 1954) plate 19 (hereafter *Lib. fig.*); M. Reeves and B. Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore* (Oxford 1972) plate 32 (hereafter *Figurae*).

⁵ Hanning, *Vision* 20.

⁶ T. Mommsen, *Medieval and Renaissance Studies* (Ithaca 1959) 268-269, 277-284.

This was carried to its highest and most explicit statement by Eusebius. In its final version Eusebius' *History of the Church* gathers the life of the People of God from Abraham to Constantine into one great movement in which the Roman Empire becomes the latest instrument of God. Books IX and X rise to a paean of triumph in Constantine, who is the new Abraham and the new Zerubbabel to rebuild the Church. Under him a new day has dawned 'bright and radiant, with no cloud overshadowing it.'⁷ Orosius expanded still further the concept of Rome as the chosen nation progressing towards a full Christianity, a new Israel whose history also could be interpreted typologically to reveal the development of the divine plan.⁸ His main legacy to the Middle Ages was, according to Hanning, the possibility of making a synthesis between national history and Biblical exegesis.⁹ These two writers created the framework within which medieval thinkers viewed the meaning of history. The core of meaning was concerned with salvation history as unfolded in the Bible, but God's providence could be traced in the workings of universal history: His footsteps in secular history were to be marked and interpreted. It was even possible to detect some kind of human progress in that earthly civilisation had improved under the influence of Christianity, while the conversion of more peoples measured advance in human history.¹⁰ This framework enabled Bede — to cite only one early example — to place the events of Anglo-Saxon history and the growth of the *ecclesia anglicana* within the context of providential history¹¹ and it becomes essential to later thinkers such as Joachim of Fiore.

But if the events between the First and Second Coming were now assuming more significance, towards what end were they leading? Early Christians had been much under the influence of late Jewish apocalyptic in which varying concepts of a messianic age had been grafted onto the older expectation of a final glorious era within time. The compilation of the so-called Sibylline Books, an amalgam of Jewish and Christian prophecies, was well known and accepted by many of the early Christian writers. In general these pointed towards the universal reign of a messiah-king in an age of peace and plenty. Professor Alexander emphasized the Jewish concept of this age as a *Zwischenreichen*, a dispensation intermediate between the present and the future worlds,¹² and

⁷ Eusebius, *History of the Church* (Harmondsworth 1965) 381ff.

⁸ Hanning, *Vision* 37–42.

⁹ *Ibid.* 42.

¹⁰ Mommsen, *Studies* 277–278, 284–285.

¹¹ Example cited by Hanning, *Vision* 67.

¹² P. Alexander, 'The Medieval Legend of the Last Roman Emperor and its Messianic Origin,' *Journal of the Warburg and Courtauld Institutes* 41 (1978) 8.

this, perhaps, provided the basis for the Christian idea of the millennium which first appears in the Apocalypse:

Et vidi angelum descendentem de caelo, habentem clavem abyssi, et catenam magnam in manu sua. Et apprehendit draconem, serpentem antiquum, qui est diabolus et Satanas, et ligavit eum per annos mille; et misit eum in abyssum, et clausit, et signavit super illum, ut non seducat amplius gentes donec consummentur mille anni; et post haec oportet illum solvi modico tempore. (Apoc. 20.1-3)

This mysterious prophecy has been the subject of speculation ever since but one feature seems clear: that the millennium was originally intended to be of limited duration, coming to an end within some kind of 'time.' Early Christians, such as Papias and Justin Martyr, focused their hopes on this vision, which they saw as an age of earthly beatitude. Although Origen in the third century attacked these materialistic visions and argued for a purely spiritual millennium, the dream of a future age of gold continued into the fourth and fifth centuries in the West, with Lactantius drawing on the Sibylline oracles and Commodianus emphasizing a final flowering of the earth.¹³ Within this early millennialism, however, there was always an ambiguity as to whether the final glorious reign would be an apotheosis of this world's history or a stage beyond it. Thus, for instance, Tertullian saw the New Jerusalem as descending from heaven to fulfill it, whereas Irenaeus stressed the idea that 'in the very creation in which they endured servitude, they [the righteous] shall also reign.'¹⁴ Only one of these early dreamers, Montanus, linked the concept of the millennium with the idea of a Third Dispensation, an Age of the Spirit to succeed those of the Father and Son.¹⁵ Yet this ultimately becomes the most powerful of the seminal ideas from which a belief in an apotheosis of history could develop.

In the fifth century, however, such ideas about the meaning of history and its end were effectively blocked. Against the play of Christian imagination over both the significance of secular progress and the budding hope of a glorious climax to history, St. Augustine set his face. He countered the optimism of Eusebius, disapproved of Orosius, his one-time disciple, and denounced the millennial dream. In St. Augustine's view of the *saeculum* there was little room either for progress within or for an apotheosis at the end of history. The

¹³ Lactantius, PL 6.808-811; Commodianus, *Instructiones* (ed. Dombart, CSEL 15.53-61); *Carmen apologeticum* (CSEL 15.175-180).

¹⁴ Irenaeus, *Adversus haereses*, PG 7.1210; for the present translation, see N. Cohn, *The Pursuit of the Millennium* (London 1957) 11.

¹⁵ Cohn, *Millennium* 8-9.

People of God were alien pilgrims, journeying through time towards a destination beyond it. Peter Brown has pointed out that there are

no verbs of historical movement in the *City of God*, no sense of progress towards ends that may be achieved in history. Augustine defused the dangerous idea of millennium by declaring that it had already begun with the Incarnation and quenched an optimistic view of secular history by declaring that the world was growing old. The *saeculum* was doomed to remain incomplete, for no human potentiality could ever reach its fulfillment within time.¹⁶

'Sed hic sive illa communis sive nostra propria talis est pax ut solacium miseriae sit potius quam beatitudinis gaudium.'¹⁷

In one sense, it is true, St. Augustine did leave to future generations symbols of progress in history; for it was he who gave the Middle Ages the great time patterns of the three *tempora*, *ante legem*, *sub lege*, *sub gratia*, derived from St. Paul, and the six great ages (*aetates*), symbolised in the six days of Creation, which had moved to a climax in the Advent of the New Adam in the Sixth Age, as the old Adam had been created on the sixth day. Progression in a divine order was implicit in both these patterns, but for Augustine, as far as the time process was concerned, progression had already been consummated in the First Advent. The Seventh — the Sabbath Age — was not a further stage in time, for the Sixth, he held, would run until at the Second Advent time would be wound up. The Seventh, the Sabbath Age, which, corresponding to the climax of the Creation Week, offered great potentiality as a symbol of an historical climax, was treated ambiguously by St. Augustine. He distinguished it from the Eighth Day of eternity, which was the felicity of an endless Sabbath, yet refused to make it a distinct age of human history. Rather it seems to represent at times the rest of the redeemed souls, running concurrently with the Sixth Age; while in outlining the Six Days he says:

Sexta nunc agitur nullo generationum numero metienda propter id quod dictum est: *Non est vestrum scire* etc. Post hanc tamquam in die septimo requiescet Deus. . . . haec tamen septima erit sabbatum nostrum, cuius finis non erit vespera, sed dominicus dies velut octavus aeternus.¹⁸

Thus the alluring ideas of millennium and Sabbath Age were placed outside the range of visionary speculation on a climax to history. For the medieval disciples of St. Augustine that climax was already past. The space between the First and Second Advents was one of waiting, a period in which nothing significant happens except the garnering of souls.

¹⁶ P. Brown, 'Saint Augustine' in *Trends in Medieval Political Thought*, ed. B. Smalley (Oxford 1965) 11. See also his *Augustine of Hippo* (London 1967) 156, 296–297.

¹⁷ *De civitate Dei* 19.27 (ed. J. Weldon, London 1924, p. 446).

¹⁸ *Ibid.* 22.30 (646 Weldon). See A. Luneau, *L'Histoire du salut chez les Pères de l'Église* (Paris 1964) 35–52, on the pre-Augustinian origins of the Seven Ages.

It is somewhat ironical, however, that, although St. Augustine's thought dominated the early Middle Ages in so many ways, hope for history was always liable to escape from this control. Robert Hanning has argued, for instance, that it was the Eusebian-Orosian affirmation of divine purpose in secular history which inspired the first attempts to find meaning in British and Anglo-Saxon history.¹⁹ Men could not refrain from seeking the signs of divine operation in their own past; nor could they altogether stifle hopes for an earthly future. Although early millennialism had been suppressed, there lingered hopes, if not of a full divine millennium, at least of an earthly climax to history. These came to a focus in the idea of a Last World Emperor. Paul Alexander has unravelled the strange beginnings of this myth: 'The legend of the Last Roman Emperor is first attested in the Syriac Apocalypse of Pseudo-Methodius, composed in northern Mesopotamia during the third quarter of the seventh century. It is impossible to say with certainty whether this first evidence represents at the same time the historical origin of the legend.'²⁰ Alexander shows that the background to this prophecy was the tribulation of Christians under the Moslem onslaught and the faithlessness of local church leaders. From these the writer turns away to Byzantium as the only source of salvation. At the height of their power the Moslems will be defeated by a 'king of the Greeks' who will drive them back into the desert and free the lands of the Empire. Very soon — in the seventh or early-eighth century — this text was translated into Greek. In both the Syriac and Greek texts the Emperor's reign culminates in an act of abdication. When Antichrist appears, the Emperor will ascend Golgotha and deposit his diadem on the Cross. He will stretch out his hands to heaven and hand over his imperial power to God. Then Antichrist will seduce many peoples until he is slain by Christ at the Second Coming. It is easy to see why this prophecy should so quickly have reached Greek circles; it is more remarkable that in the same period (late-seventh or early-eighth century) it was carried to a monastery in Gaul and there translated into Latin by a monk, Peter. This testifies to the need for prophetic expectation to sustain men in an insecure and troubled world. Thus the hope of a last great emperor enters Western consciousness, to be incorporated in the tenth century by the monk Adso into his tract on Antichrist, and at some later point to be attached to the oracle of the Tiburtine Sibyl, which originally carried no prophetic hope of a glorious climax in history.²¹

¹⁹ Hanning, *Vision* 42.

²⁰ P. Alexander, 'Byzantium and the Migration of Literary Works and Motifs,' *Medievalia et Humanistica* n.s. 2 (1971) 60. The following account summarises Alexander's main points.

²¹ On the Tiburtine Sibyl, see P. Alexander, *The Oracle of Baalbek* (Dumbarton Oaks 1967); E. Sackur, *Sibyllinische Texte u. Forschung. Pseudo-Methodius, Adso u. die tiburtinische Sibylle* (Halle 1898) 177–187. See also M. Rangheri, 'La Epistola ad Gerbergam reginam de

A Syriac legend thus supplied the Western imagination with an image on which to focus hopes for a this-worldly apotheosis. The repressed messianic or millennial dreams of Jewish and early Christian minds seem to come to the surface again in the form of this new political saviour. Three points must be noticed. First, the legend rests on the belief, supported by several New Testament texts, that Antichrist would not appear until the 'Roman' Empire had fulfilled its God-given purpose. Secondly, the words in which the remarkable abdication scene at Golgotha are described carry over-tones of Byzantine imperial doctrine, with the mystic aura of glory surrounding the divinely favoured office. Yet, thirdly, this political deliverance and triumph does not constitute either a millennium or a Sabbath Age, that is, a new regime on earth. The reign of the great emperor *precedes* the appearance of Antichrist. Evil is not overcome, and the transitory nature of human glory is emphasized by the collapse of the Emperor's role at the appearance of Antichrist. The final battle against evil can be won only by the supernatural forces of Christ and His Angels. In later versions of this prophecy the worldly aspect of this final age of peace is underlined by the description of men eating and drinking in security just before the onslaught of Antichrist. Now, these words come from Matt. 24.38–39, where the context is not at all the peace of a messianic kingdom, but the false security of worldly people when their end is coming upon them. If the earlier Judaeo-Christian dream of a messianic age did enter the Middle Ages in the garb of the Last World Emperor, it remained, as a rule, a limited hope. Yet, even subject to deterioration or collapse, a political age of gold was an enticing will o' the wisp, always dancing just ahead. The association of the Last Emperor with Jerusalem naturally linked him with the crusading motif in the eleventh century. Benzo of Alba adapted the prophecy to Henry IV, claiming the crusader's role for him in 1086 and, in this case, going much further than most in expecting Henry to meet and overcome Antichrist in Jerusalem.²² More significantly, perhaps, it has been shown that the expectation of a triumphing Emperor interpenetrates the many other motives of the First Crusade, among both the popular armies and the feudal leaders.²³ By the twelfth century the prophecy was firmly attached to the Sibylline Books and was quoted as such by both Otto of Freising and Godfrey of Viterbo.²⁴

ortu et tempore Antichristi di Adson di Montier-en-Der e le sue fonti,' *Studi Medievali* 3rd ser. 14 (1973) 708–709 n. 79, 710 n. 85, where he argues that the version of the myth in the Tiburtine Sibyl's oracle could not have been derived from the pseudo-Methodius text.

²² MGH SS 11.604–605, 617, 668–669.

²³ Cohn, *Millennium* 54–58. See also the unpublished thesis of A. Hounam, University of London.

²⁴ Otto of Freising, *Gesta Friderici imperatoris* ed. G. Waitz (Hanover 1884) 8; Godfrey of Viterbo, MGH SS 22.145–147, 376.

But for most theologians history lay under the shadow of Augustinianism. The duration of the Sixth Age had little more to reveal until the Last Things. Yet, in spite of the warning 'It is not for you to know the times and the seasons . . .' (Acts 1.7), there was room here for speculation. A chink of hope has been shown by Professor Lerner to have opened up through the unexpected mechanism of an arithmetical puzzle. Jerome of all people — determined opponent of 'the fable of one thousand years' that he was — became interested in a piece of eschatological arithmetic: namely, the difference between the prophet Daniel's two predictions of 1290 days during which the abomination of desolation (i.e., the reign of Antichrist) would last and the 1335 days of waiting for the faithful.²⁵ Jerome concluded that there would be 45 'days' — that is, 1335 minus 1290 — between the death of Antichrist and the Last Judgement, a space which, he thought, believers would spend in repentance. Lerner fastens on this time between the fall of Antichrist and the Second Coming because he sees it as anticipating a crucial point in Joachim's expectation: namely, that the Age of the Spirit would be fully manifest in the space between victory over the great Antichrist and the end.²⁶ But Jerome's argument for the space of 45 days appears to arise simply out of the need to resolve an arithmetical discrepancy. However, this 'space' seems like a small crack in the hard rock-face blocking the end of history into which, over the centuries, a little soil crept and finally a seed of hope sprouted in the twelfth century. Bede saw it as a period of uncertain duration and transitory rest, linking it with the opening of the seventh seal in the Apocalypse. But he was clearly far from any notion of a climax to human history, for he followed Augustine firmly when, in expounding the Seven Ages of the World Week, he saw the Seventh, the Sabbath Age, as the rest of just souls, running concurrently with the Six Ages from Abel to the end of the *saeculum*. Lerner shows that in the following centuries commentators extended this 'space' after Antichrist and emphasized its purpose for penance until the *Glossa ordinaria* struck a new note when the gloss on Dan. 12.12 pronounced: 'dies quietis et pacis post mortem Antichristi xlv superioribus adduntur ad refregerium sanctorum et ad penitentiam subversorum.'²⁷ Perhaps this is a small indication of a new attitude towards the meaning of the time process which appears in the first half of the twelfth century. The discussion about the purpose of an interval after Antichrist should therefore be placed in the larger context of a developing philosophy of history.

If for most twelfth-century theologians their concept of history was still dominated by Augustinianism, there are clear indications of a new stirring of

²⁵ Lerner, 'Refreshment of the Saints' 102.

²⁶ *Ibid.* 101, 116–117, 143–144.

²⁷ *Ibid.* 109.

interest in the movement of history, its periodization, its 'progress,' its conclusion. There is a striking awareness of *change* as a factor in human experience which at times almost seems at odds with the timeless realities of the Faith. We need to look closely at a group of thinkers in the first half of the twelfth century who were certainly concerned with the meaning of history before Joachim began to write. Of those particularly germane to this discussion, Honorius of Autun may well have been read by Joachim. There are several specific interpretations in his writings which are almost echoed by Joachim.²⁸ But our main concern is with Honorius' sense of movement through the ages of history, as embraced in the timeless and repeated liturgical acts of faith.²⁹ As he expounds the symbolism of liturgy, he weaves an interplay of the two Augustinian patterns of history. First he introduces the three *tempora* into which the whole existence of the world can be divided: *tempus ante legem, sub lege, sub gratia*. There is no explicit connection here between a threefold division and the work of the Trinity. This, of course, is the standard orthodox 'pattern of threes,' perhaps maintained later as a conscious corrective to Joachimism. In the *Gemma animae*³⁰ Honorius expounds the stages in celebrating the Mass in terms of the three *tempora* combined with the six *aetates* of the world. *Tempus ante legem* contains three subdivisions — Adam to Noah, Noah to Abraham, Abraham to Moses; *tempus legis*, two divisions — Moses to David, David to Christ; *tempus gratiae*, which is caught up into the

²⁸ Three examples may be cited. (a) In his commentary on the Song of Songs Honorius uses the Pauline figure of the body and its members, equating the eyes to apostles, ears to monks, nose to 'magistri,' mouth to priests (presbyteri), hands to knights, and feet to 'rustici'; compare Joachim's figure of the *Dispositio novi ordinis* (*Lib. fig.* plate 12), where the same pattern is used with a different equation of members to orders. (b) In Book III of Honorius' *Gemma animae* the liturgical year of the Church is interpreted as symbolising the pilgrimage of the individual soul and also of the Church from this life to the next. Joachim's figure of the *Mysterium ecclesiae* (*Lib. fig.* plate 19) is more complex, relating the liturgical year to the ages of history and the three *status*, but there is a similarity of concept; compare in particular Honorius' comment 'Per tempus a Septuagesima usque ad Pascha alleluia intermittitur; nos exprimit, qui hic in labore et tristitia relinquimur' with Joachim's 'a prima hebdomada qui intitulatur LXX omittimus cantare canticum Domini quod est Alleluia, et pro eo utimur tractu qui est carmen doloris. Quia quando in primo parente ejecti scimus de paradiso et pervenimus ad vallem lacrimarum tunc omisimus cantare canticum Domini eo quod esse cepimus in terra aliena.' (c) In his exposition of the Psalms Honorius interprets the *forma* of the psalter as follows: its form represents the *novus homo* in Christ; its triangularity stands for the Trinity; its ten strings are the decalogue. In his early exposition of this figure Joachim makes precisely the same points (*Psalterium decem chordarum*, ed. Venice 1527 [hereafter *Psalt.*] fols. 230^{ff.}), although later he develops the symbolism of the strings in an original way (see *Figurae* 55–59, 201–206). All these derive from a common stock of symbolic interpretation, and so the influence of Honorius cannot be proved but taken together they suggest its likelihood.

²⁹ Honorius of Autun, *Selectorum psalmorum expositio*, PL 172.273–274.

³⁰ *Gemma animae*, PL 172.559–560.

Mass at the moment of the elevation of the Host, corresponds to the sixth *aetas* from the Incarnation to the Second Coming. Again, he interprets the repeated cycle of canonical hours in terms of the movement through the whole of time towards eternity.³¹ The *prima vigilia* signifies once more *tempus ante legem*, of which the three *horae* symbolise the procession of the first three *aetates* — Adam–Noah, Noah–Abraham, Abraham–Moses — and he expounds the psalms to be sung in these terms. Similarly, the *secunda vigilia* represents *tempus legis* and the fourth and fifth *aetates*. The third *vigilia* (*tempus gratiae*) has a significant addition, for the three *horae* into which it is divided symbolise *tempus apostolicae praedictionis*, *tempus persecutionis*, *tempus pacis* under Constantine. Here is the beginning of a developing pattern in the sixth *aetas*, but Honorius does not extend it any further.³² Nonetheless, the whole time process gains in significance when subsumed into the unchanging liturgical round by which the timeless God is served.

Honorius is strictly Augustinian in relegating the Seventh, the Sabbath Age, to the eternal rest beyond the Last Judgement. That little sprout of hope in some form of earthly consummation is, however, seen to be developing in his thought, although, curiously enough, unrelated to his time structures of threes and sevens and thus hardly envisioned as a new stage in God's self-revelation or in the meaning of history. Nevertheless, as Lerner points out, Honorius gives this interval a more positive purpose than any previous commentators.³³ When expounding the symbolism of Holy Week in terms of Last Days, he says that the three days before Easter signify the three years of Antichrist's rule. Then, at the kindling of the new Easter fire, the death of Antichrist is celebrated 'et illo tempore ignis Spiritus Sancti in ecclesia reaccenditur.'³⁴ In these days 'maxima multitudo baptizabitur.' Certainly Easter is only a *transitus*, 'quia Ecclesia de peregrinatione ad patriam transire praedicatur,' yet it symbolises a time of positive and great rejoicing. Honorius actually uses as its type the rebuilding of Jerusalem after the return from Babylon, a figure constantly in Joachim's mind as foreshadowing the Age of the Spirit. Honorius writes:

Laudate Dominum de caelis illud tempus umbrae denuntiat quo populis a Babylone reversus templum Domino reaedicabat, et illud tempus ostendit

³¹ *Ibid.* 615–626.

³² Cf. G. Bischoff, 'Early Premonstratensian Eschatology: The Apocalyptic Myth' in *The Spirituality of Western Christendom*, ed. E. R. Elder (Kalamazoo 1976) 54, on Eberwin of Steinfeld's interpretation of the wine jars at the marriage of Cana: 'The time of the Church is now divided into the six ages, symbolized by the six jars of Cana, because the Church exists in historical time and therefore such historical existence is significant. The timeless unity and homogeneity of the Church's existence have clearly become a problem. Change is now perceived within this existence.'

³³ Lerner, 'Refreshment of the Saints' 111.

³⁴ *Gemma animae*, PL 172.679.

quo Ecclesia, occiso Antichristo, Dominum laudabit, et per terrorem lapsos, in domum Dei poenitentia restaurabit, hi tres Psalmi ideo sub uno Gloria Patri psalluntur, quia tunc Christiani, Judaei et Gentiles in una religione Dominum laudare noscuntur.³⁵

Again, in his commentary on the Song of Songs, Honorius returns to the theme of the conversion of the pagans when commenting on the verses

Veni, dilecte mi, egregiamur in agrum, commoremur in villis. Mane surgamus ad vineas; videamus si floruit vinea, si flores fructus parturiunt, si floruerunt mala punica; ibi dabo tibi ubera mea. Mandragorae dederunt odorem. In portis nostris omnia poma: nova et vetera, dilecte mi, servavi tibi.³⁶

In the dawn after the night of Antichrist the Church is to go forth early into the field of the world to sow the Word of God; it will recall lapsed Christians, rebuild churches, and, sojourning among the pagans ('in villis'), convert them to the true faith. The mandrake, that plant shaped like a headless human body, signifies the pagans who, having lost their head, Antichrist, will receive their true head in Christ and give forth a sweet odour of good works at the gates of the Church. Thus at the very end of time there is to be a kind of sunset glow over this 'tempus pacis post mortem Antichristi,'³⁷ with an emphasis on repentance of Christians and conversion of Gentiles as a preparation for the Last Judgement. But this seems to have little connection with Honorius' patterns of the three *tempora* and six *aetates* and therefore to be unrelated to any theory of progress in history. The expectation for the end of time is neither of a millennium nor of a Sabbath Age which would represent a new stage in God's self-revelation, but of a *transitus*, a mercifully granted interval to prepare for Judgement.

The paradox of the moving generations of men set against their timeless unity in the Faith again occupies both Hugh of St. Victor and his disciple Adam of Whitehorn. In his *De sacramentis*,³⁸ Hugh several times repeats the phrase 'sive praecedentes, sive subsequentes,' or a similar one, emphasizing that there is one salvation for the whole procession of the generations of men. To express both movement and unity in history, he turns to the pattern of three *tempora* which he designates as *tempus naturalis legis*, *tempus scriptae legis*, *tempus gratiae*. Again, in *De arca Noe mystica*,³⁹ he divides the Ark into these three parts which run, of course, from Adam to Moses (or the twelve patriarchs), Moses to the Incarnation, the First Advent to the *finem saeculi*.

³⁵ *Ibid.* 627.

³⁶ *Expositio in Cantica Canticorum* 7.11–13 (PL 172.471–472).

³⁷ *Ibid.* 472.

³⁸ *De sacramentis christiane fidei*, PL 176.312–313.

³⁹ *De arca Noe mystica*, PL 176.688–690.

The progressive self-revelation of God was built into the Ark of Salvation, but the Ark was finished at the First Coming, and no more will be added. Its function now is to withstand the restless waves as history rolls on to its conclusion. Adam of Whitehorn follows Hugh closely in seeing the life of the *tabernacula Christi* — that is, Holy Church — divided into the *tempora* of natural law, written law, and grace.⁴⁰ He fuses these with the six *aetates* of Adam–Noah, Noah–Abraham, Abraham–David, David–the *transmigratio Babylonis*, thence to the Incarnation, and finally, the sixth *aetas* from the First to the Second Coming. He goes on to describe the seventh — ‘nunc est in requie animarum’ — and the eighth — ‘in felicitate corporum resurgentium.’ He sums up the theme of progressive movement through time contained within the unity of all truth thus:

Per haec itaque tria tempora, per has sex aetates, cum ordinibus gestorum et dispositionem eventuum, secundum unitatem significationum et diversitatem sacramentorum, unam in una fide salutem operantium, unum quoque Creatorem, unum etiam, eundemque Salvatorem, sive adventum ejus praecedendo, sive subsequendo concorditer clamantium; sancta Ecclesia in fide, spe et charitate currens ab exordio saeculi usque ad finem, a labore ad requiem, a tenebris ad lucem, ad felicitatem ab aerumna, ab exilio ad patriam, a moerore ad gaudium, et a carcere tendit ad regnum. . . .⁴¹

Thus, although the movement of history is from labour to rest, from darkness to light, from exile to the homeland, this consummation lies beyond time in eternity.

Like Honorius, Gerhoh of Reichersberg in his *De quarta vigilia noctis* uses the symbolism of the night vigils to illumine the meaning of the Church's history.⁴² His interpretation starts with the night spent by the storm-tossed disciples on the Sea of Galilee which prefigures the perils to be endured by the Church. In the first vigil the storm of persecution broke, in which the martyrs triumphed until wind and waves were temporarily calmed in the great tranquillity under Constantine. The second storm of contrary winds was created by Arius, Sabellius, and other heretics against whom confessors laboured and prevailed. In the third vigil the ship of the Church was imperilled by inner corruption of life against which the holy fathers and Roman pontiffs from Gregory I to Gregory VII contended. In all these struggles the Church had triumphed by divine aid, but the conflict between Papacy and Empire, arising under Gregory VII, had marked the onset of the greatest storm, that of the fourth vigil. Gerhoh was deeply concerned over simony and schism in the Church: ‘ex tunc cepit avaricia nova in urbe Roma.’⁴³ For avarice was the

⁴⁰ *De tripartito tabernaculo*, PL 198.691–692.

⁴¹ *Ibid.* 692.

⁴² *De quarta vigilia noctis*, MGH SS *Libelli de lite* 3.508–525.

⁴³ *Ibid.* 509.

root of evil, and the strong wind of avarice now blowing was greatly to be feared. It was rising into the tempest of Antichrist, represented by the schismatics. Only Christ walking on the water could rescue His Church from being engulfed. At this point the disciple to whom Gerhoh is expounding this symbolism points out that Christ comes to His disciples in the ship and stills the storm *before* they reach land. This appears to mean that before Christ comes in judgement at the end of time, he will come to the still-voyaging Church to mitigate the perils of the tempest, 'ut fiat tranquillitas magna.'⁴⁴ To this Gerhoh replies very positively: this is not a matter of conjecture but firm faith and certain hope: 'quod sicut solis ortum prevenit aurora, qua nox fugatur, etiam priusquam sol super terram videatur, sic manifestum Christi adventum precedet quedam claritas, consimilis aurorae solis ortum prevenientis contra densissimas tenebras per novissimum Antichristum in toto mundo dilatas. . . .'⁴⁵ So Christ, having stilled the tempest, enters the boat. The distance still to be traversed before reaching the shore of eternal peace is the space between the destruction of Antichrist and the Second Coming, a time in which the Church will be purged from simony and all other impurities and Christian people will be filled with great joy. In his *De investigatione Antichristi* Gerhoh also speaks briefly of spiritual leaders who will reform the Church just before the Second Advent, while in his commentary on Ps. 64 he makes a prophetic affirmation of belief that the prince of the apostles will be the ruler of the whole orb.⁴⁶ So, once again, we find in a twelfth-century writer this pronounced concern with the pattern of history — in this case focused on the significance of post-Incarnation history, as prefigured in the storm on Galilee — together with an optimistic expectation about the final moments of the earthly *saeculum* which creeps in in spite of his quotation of the conventional and pessimistic text from Matt. 24.12: 'And because iniquity shall abound, the love of many shall wax cold.' But this is still not the final stage of a full pattern of history which mounts to its logical climax. As with Honorius, it arises rather out of a particular piece of exegesis, but Gerhoh goes even further than Honorius in envisaging a spiritual renewal of the Church. The deep longing of the twelfth-century reformers which is expressed in movements of return to the apostolic life is also seen in this eschatological hope of the interval to be granted by Christ at the end.

Perhaps the writer in this group who was most concerned with the relationship between change and diversity, on the one hand, and unchanging realities,

⁴⁴ *Ibid.* 513.

⁴⁵ *Ibid.* 514.

⁴⁶ *De investigatione Antichristi*, MGH SS *Libelli de lite* 3.352; *Commentarius in Psalmum LXIV* *ibid.* 467. This has been interpreted as foreshadowing the idea of the Angelic Pope; see below, p. 305.

on the other, was Anselm of Havelberg. He begins his first Dialogue⁴⁷ with a chapter headed 'De unitate fidei et multiformitate vivendi ab Abel justo usque ad novissimum electum' and this embodies the problem to which he addresses himself. People are saying: Why is there so much novelty in the Church? Why have so many new orders of clerics and monks arisen? 'Quinimo quis non contemnat Christianam religionem tot varietatibus subjectam, tot ab inventionibus immutatam, tot novis legibus et consuetudinibus agitatam, tot regulis et moribus fere annuatim innovatis fluctuantem?' It is argued, he says, that in religion 'tanto esse contemptibiliorem, quanto mobiliorum,' for how can anything so changing, so variable, so unstable be worthy of imitation? These critics, says Anselm,⁴⁸ do not take account of the fact that from the beginning the Church of God has been one in essence but multi-form in its modes, laws, and institutions, as the Holy Spirit vivifies and rules it from Abel to the latest of the elect. His vision is of the Church of God renewing its youth like the eagle throughout the whole time process, 'salvo semper sanctae Trinitatis fidei fundamento, praeter quod nemo aliud deinceps ponere potest quamvis in superedificatione.'⁴⁹ We seem here to be on the edge of a Trinitarian interpretation of the historical process, but, in fact, the 'pattern of threes' adopted by Anselm is the accepted *ante legem, sub lege, sub gratia*, which does not specifically connect the work of the three Persons with successive stages of history. He emphasizes that these represent progressive stages in spiritual understanding:

quia oportebat ut secundum processum temporum crescerent signa spiritualium gratiarum, quae magis ac magis ipsam veritatem declararent, et sic cum effectu salutis incrementum acciperet de tempore in tempus cognitio veritatis: et ita primo quidem bona, deinde meliora, ad ultimum vero optima proposita sunt.⁵⁰

But the third stage is already far advanced and there is no further stage of progress to come.

Anselm also uses the Augustinian seven *aetates* and, more significantly, he divides Church history since the Incarnation into seven *status*, symbolised in the opening of the seven seals in the Apocalypse. Here, as far as pattern goes, he comes close to Joachim's exegesis: the four horsemen of the first four seals represent the stages which saw the witness of apostles, martyrs, doctors, and religious. In the fifth *status* the Church still labours against false brethren and heretics, and expects the sixth in which the earth-shaking persecution of Antichrist will take place. In this periodisation of Church history after the

⁴⁷ *Dialogi*, PL 188.1141–1142.

⁴⁸ *Ibid.* 1143–1144.

⁴⁹ *Ibid.* 1149.

⁵⁰ *Ibid.* 1160.

Incarnation, Anselm is making a decisive move away from Augustinianism and, albeit unconsciously, preparing the way for Joachim. But in this sequence the crucial point is the interpretation of the 'silence in heaven for the space of half-an-hour' at the opening of the seventh seal.⁵¹ Joachim, like Anselm and others, could plot out the Church's history in terms of persecutions, rising to a climax in Antichrist; but for him it was essential that the silence of the seventh seal after the death of Antichrist symbolised the Sabbath Age, the third *status* on earth. Anselm, on the contrary, says:

Sigillum septimum, septimus Ecclesiae status est, in quo futurum est silentium, quia post tribulationes Ecclesiae, quae in multa tristitia parturivit filios Dei, post iudicium quod erit in adventu Filii Dei, in momento, in ictu oculi, omnibus jam consummatis, silentium divinae contemplationis erit, annus jubilaus instaurabitur, octava infinitae beatitudinis celebrabitur.⁵²

Here the seventh *status* is placed after the Last Judgement and seems to merge into the Eighth Day of eternity. There is no Sabbath Age or third *status* within history. Anselm of Havelberg approaches the preoccupations of Joachim in his concern with the diverse ways in which God has progressively revealed Himself through the movement of history, but he stops short of any concept of a further revelation of the Spirit in a new *status* after the death of Antichrist, and allows the pregnant seventh-seal silence to be caught up into the other-worldly context.

Of all this group of writers, perhaps Rupert of Deutz, in his great work *De Trinitate et operibus eius*, comes closest to the vision of Joachim. Here the whole of history, from the creation of the world to its consummation, is interpreted as the work of the Trinity. Hence the threefold division of history which follows is now explicitly seen as the operation of the three Persons:

Est autem tripartitum eiusdem Trinitatis opus, a conditione mundi usque ad finem eius. Primum est ab ortu primae lucis usque ad lapsum primi hominis. Secundum, ab eodem lapsu primi hominis usque ad passionem secundi hominis, Jesu Christi Filii Dei. Tertium, a resurrectione eiusdem usque ad saeculi consummationem, id est, generalem mortuorum resurrectionem. Et primum quidem Patris, secundum autem Filii, tertium vero Spiritus Sancti proprium opus est.⁵³

Moreover, Rupert is concerned with exactly the same problem as Joachim: that is, how the one undivided God, lord of all history, is yet revealed through the distinctive works proper to each Person:

Plane inseparabilis Trinitas, unus Deus inseparabiliter operatur. Verum tamen, singulis horum, id est, Patris, et Filii et Spiritus Sancti, sicut personae proprietates, ita et in perfectione mundi considerata est actio propria,

⁵¹ *Ibid.* 1149–1159.

⁵² *Ibid.* 1159.

⁵³ *De Trinitate et operibus eius libri XLII*, PL 167.198–199.

videlicet, ut Patris creatio, Filii redemptio, sancti Spiritus proprium sit opus creaturae innovatio.⁵⁴

With the point firmly made that all three Persons are active all the time, Rupert then divides his work into three parts. The first, dealing with the creative work of the Father, is on the seven Days of Creation. The second covers the six ages of the World Week, beginning in Adam, Noah, Abraham, David, the Babylonian captivity, and the Incarnation. This embodies the redemptive work of the Son, but, following the principles laid down, the Seven Gifts of the Spirit were active throughout these ages, starting with *timor dei* in the ejection from paradise and working up to the sixth gift, *intellectus*, when the Scriptures were opened at the Incarnation. *Sapientia* remains for the seventh *aetas*. Thus there is a progressive movement through history, but when we come to the third part, the work peculiar to the Spirit, the vision becomes less certain.⁵⁵ This begins with the Resurrection of Christ and continues to the General Resurrection, but Rupert cannot treat it as an historical progression. He has two difficulties. One is that the climax of history has already been reached, and, though the Spirit through its seven gifts is being made manifest throughout the period in all its developments (for instance, *scientia* is embodied in the introduction of the seven liberal arts),⁵⁶ yet there is a sense in which history is now running downhill. This is emphasized in the fact that, while in part two the seven gifts are seen developing progressively upwards from *timor dei*, in this third part the order is reversed. Rupert begins, after a prologue, with two books devoted to *sapientia* and ends with *timor dei* as a preparation for the Last Judgement. If we recall Joachim's figure of the psalter with ten strings in which *Homo* ascends triumphantly from *Timor Dei* at the lowest string, through the seven gifts and three theological virtues to attain celestial things and to be placed above the angelic choirs, the contrast in vision is striking.⁵⁷ Rupert's other problem is how to interpret the seventh *aetas*. Following the Augustinian tradition, he cannot conceive of it as coming in an ordinary time sequence after the sixth *aetas*, yet it is distinct from the Eighth Day. He tackles this question more explicitly than most writers in an interesting passage:

Septima mundi aetas, non pro tempore, vel temporum ordine aetas dicitur, aut septima nuncupatur. Neque enim quomodo quinta quartae, quomodo sexta quintae, sic illa huic sextae temporaliter succedit, sed conjuncta velut ex latere, usque ad finem saeculi, usque ad universalis diem resurrectionis, cum ea currit. Est autem alterius saeculi secretum, in quo electorum animae

⁵⁴ *Ibid.* 199.

⁵⁵ *Ibid.* 1571ff.

⁵⁶ *Ibid.* 1763.

⁵⁷ *Lib. fig.* plate 13.

depositis corporibus, felice sabbatismo, cum Deo requiescunt, quaequumque per sex aetates mundi, diversis meritis operum, differentes quidem mansiones, sed eandem requiem ingredi meruerunt. Ipsa Sabbatum, id est, requies dicitur.⁵⁸

Thus even Rupert draws back from the expectation that the seventh gift of the Spirit, *sapientia*, will be made manifest *temporaliter*.

In Eberwin of Steinfeld, as Professor Bischoff points out in his suggestive essay on early Premonstratensian eschatology, we once again meet this twelfth-century phenomenon of concern with the time process in a sense which constituted a break with the Augustinian view of history.⁵⁹ Eberwin uses the symbol of the six jars of wine at the marriage at Cana to work out a periodisation of Church history which recognizes change within the Church's existence and views it as a 'graduated process in which the flow of Church history accelerates towards its end.'⁶⁰ Bischoff links this novel line of thought with Anselm of Havelberg and, to a lesser extent, with Norbert of Xanten, all three Premonstratensians. He believes that 'the momentous step taken by both Eberwin and Anselm of discarding the augustinian tradition by the periodization of church history' was inspired by the work of Rupert of Deutz.⁶¹ But if Rupert had provided the tools for an attack on Augustinianism, at one point his conservatism apparently led him into sharp opposition to Eberwin. For Eberwin had carried an emphasis on 'something more to come' to a dangerously near-Joachimist position in his contention that in the last age within history, which was now beginning, the Church would grow in perfection through a new order of the humble, surpassing all the old orders. Thus, Bischoff concludes, we must recognize 'the emergence of a new and un-augustinian eschatology... in connection with the most radical wing of the canonical reform, whose adherents followed the rules of the *ordo monasterii*.'⁶² The Incarnation is seen no longer so much as the climactic *end* of redemptive history as its *centre*, while the periodisation of Church history leads logically to the expectation of a further state of perfection before the end. Here we are surely on the verge of Joachimism.

⁵⁸ *De Trinitate*, PL 167.1567.

⁵⁹ G. Bischoff, 'Early Premonstratensian Eschatology' 53: 'The augustinian concept of history attached no significance to history after Christ'; p. 54: 'Augustine's perception of the punctual, hence undifferentiated unity of the Church's existence has yielded to a view that detects movement.'

⁶⁰ *Ibid.* 54.

⁶¹ *Ibid.* 59. Among earlier writers, Primasius, Bedé, and Haymo had approached the idea of interpreting the opening of the seven seals in the Apocalypse as symbolising periods in the Church's history, but their interpretations are in general and moralistic terms, with few specific historical applications.

⁶² *Ibid.* 67.

The visions of Hildegard of Bingen stand in a category by themselves. She certainly prophesied a period of conversion and peace before the Last Day, grounding this on two arguments: first, that the full work of the Son must be completed before the winding up of history; secondly, that as peace reigned before the First Advent, so a period of peace, with the conversion of the Jews and others, must precede the Second Advent.⁶³ She clearly placed this between the death of Antichrist and the Last Judgement, heading one of her chapters 'Quia post ruinam Antichristi gloria Filii Dei amplificabatur,' and envisaging this as a period of joy, light, and material abundance.⁶⁴ Surprisingly enough, in two passages she seems to take for granted what no one had yet dared to suggest — that the Seventh Age, in the sense of a further stage of history, had already begun: 'Sed nunc sextus numerus finitus est et deventum est in septimum numerum in quo nunc cursus mundi velut in septima die requiei positus est.'⁶⁵ But she does not give this departure from the Augustinian view any special emphasis and the scheme of Seven Ages does not play a major part in her thought. Hildegard's visions surely embody a yearning that history should end in completion rather than in disintegration; but she does not seem to me to develop a full philosophy of history. Nor did she see any specifically Trinitarian meaning in its final stage. This last period is seen not so much as a new epoch of history as the rounding off of the work of the Son. Nonetheless, it is significant that she should have raised the old dream of blessedness on earth at just this moment.

Of the thinkers we have briefly considered, Honorius and Gerhoh stressed the positive significance of the pause between Antichrist and Last Judgement but did not relate this to a progressive doctrine of history; while the Victorines, Anselm, and Rupert were occupied with the progressive stages of God's self-revelation in history but believed that it had reached its climax in the Incarnation and — although interested in the stages of the Church's history since then — could not envisage a new turning-point in the short span of time still left in the future. Perhaps the possibilities of that 'space' between Antichrist and Judgement were developed precisely because optimism was blocked from any other route. But Eberwin of Steinfeld seems on the verge of affirming a new stage in the Church's progress, while if the post-Antichrist vision of Honorius or Gerhoh or Hildegard had been married to the Trinitarian structure of history developed by Rupert, Joachim's Age of the Spirit might have

⁶³ *Scivias sive visionum ac revelationum libri tres*, PL 197.713–715; *Liber divinarum operum simplicis hominis*, *ibid.* 1020.

⁶⁴ *Ibid.* 722, 1022, 1036.

⁶⁵ *Ibid.* 715. Bede had seen the 'silence' at the opening of the seventh seal in the Apocalypse as a period of repose for the Church after Antichrist, but apparently did not identify this with the great Seventh Day; cf. *Explanatio Apocalipsis*, PL 93.154 with *Liber de temporibus maior sive de temporum ratione*, ed. C. W. Jones (Cambridge, Mass. 1943) 202.

been anticipated. It might, indeed, have been the 'new spiritual leaders' prophesied by Gerhoh or the new 'humble order' by Eberwin rather than the 'new spiritual men' of Joachim who caught the imagination of later generations.

II

To pin down Joachim's direct debt to other twelfth-century writers, if any, is a difficult task which awaits a critical edition of his main works for any full treatment.⁶⁶ He shared with many those symbols and types which were by his time common form.⁶⁷ He used the figure of Satan bound for a thousand years as a symbol of the third *status*, but he was not a millennialist in the sense of expecting a miraculous kingdom to descend from above.⁶⁸ Like most of his contemporaries, he saw history symbolised in the Days of Creation and used St. Augustine's structure of the seven *aeates*, but — apart from St. Hildegard — he was, so far as I know, the only one to place the Seventh Age within time. He shared the recently developed symbolism of the seven-seal openings as the seven ages of the Church, but his concept of the double tribulation under the sixth seal which freed the seventh for the peace of the Sabbath Age, symbolised in the 'silence in heaven' at the seventh-seal opening, was, I think, unique. He used the orthodox division of history into three stages but, as we shall see, he could transform them into his own pattern. His references to Sibylline prophecies are interesting but slight,⁶⁹ and for the popular myth of a Last World Emperor he had no use at all. A political age of gold had no place in his vision. I do not think that in itself the mathematical calculation which had produced the concept of the 'space' between the defeat of Antichrist and the Second Coming was of crucial significance to him. Although it is true that

⁶⁶ Professor Herbert Grundmann had planned a critical edition of the *Liber concordie*, a task which Professor E. Randolph Daniel has now taken up. The *Expositio in Apocalypsim* and *Psalterium decem chordarum* are equally in need of modern editions.

⁶⁷ See n. 28. Another quite common example is the use of Peter and John as types of the orders of clergy and monks. See, for instance, the *Scutum canonicorum* of Arno of Reichersberg (PL 194.521–523), who thus interprets the episode, so beloved of Joachim, of the two disciples running to the Sepulchre; but significantly he does not come anywhere near Joachim's striking but dangerous deduction from the time sequence that the work of Peter is consummated before that of John, who arrives first but enters the Sepulchre last. I owe this reference to Dr. D. Robey.

⁶⁸ For Joachim's interpretation of Satan bound for a thousand years as the Sabbath of history, see *Expos.* fols. 210^v–212^r.

⁶⁹ Joachim's exposition of the Sybil in 1184 before Pope Lucius III and the text, *Expositio de prophetia ignota Romae reperta*, presumed to belong to this occasion, have been studied by B. McGinn, 'Joachim and the Sybil,' *Cîteaux Commentarii Cistercienses* 24 (1973) 97–138, who confirms the case for the authenticity of this text.

Joachim saw the third *status* as occurring after the destruction of the great Antichrist, he arrived at his expectation of the Age of the Spirit by another route. Joachim shared symbols of Last Things with his contemporaries but used them in his own way.

Yet the ground had been well tilled for him. A tradition of meaning in history had been inherent in Christian thought from the beginning and had been built up over the centuries, but it was the aspirations and hopes of the twelfth-century writers we have glanced at which brought expectations about the future — tremblingly — to the brink of Joachimism. The idea that the process of history was in itself significant and important as providing clues to divine purpose, the belief that eternal truths could express themselves in changing historical forms, the haunting desire for a blessedness within time which fought with the notion of deterioration and collapse before the end — these aspects of twelfth-century thought provided the setting for Joachim's prophetic affirmation; while at the level of concrete manifestation the many poverty movements which, though backward-looking in their models, were thrusting forward in new experiments, already foreshadowed Joachim's 'new spiritual men' who would move further towards perfection *in novissimis diebus*. Moreover, the desire of these writers in the previous generation to reconcile unity and diversity within history finds full expression in Joachim's intense concentration on the unity and Trinity of the Godhead at work in the time process.

The spearhead of Joachim's original thought lies in the great imaginative step which he took when he threw the full manifestation of the Third Person of the Trinity forward into the period ahead.⁷⁰ Anselm of Havelberg had seen the process of change as a developing spiritual illumination in three phases; Rupert of Deutz had seen these phases as successive manifestations of the Trinity, but, following the Augustinian tradition, could not envisage a second climax of history yet to come. Joachim, though probably unaware, broke decisively with Augustine at this point when he announced the full illumination of the Spirit as yet to come. But the full weight of his thrust forward is realised only when we grasp the shaft of his spear and understand that he was con-

⁷⁰ Henry Mottu's important book *La manifestation de l'Esprit selon Joachim de Fiore* (Neuchâtel and Paris 1977) reached me too late for adequate comment within the limits of this article. He suggests that I have underestimated Joachim's novelty, but his argument here turns on the question of how revolutionary, rather than how original, Joachim was and, though these two questions are interrelated, they are not quite the same. Joachim's originality can be clearly assessed only when he is studied in relation to his contemporaries. How far that originality carried him into revolutionary conclusions is a question involving a delicate balance between two over-statements, see below, pp. 293–97. The question of Joachim's originality was discussed briefly at the International Colloquium at Lyons in 1974; see 1274: *Année charnière — Mutations et continuités. Colloques Internationaux du Centre National de la Recherche Scientifique* (Paris 1977) 892–894.

cerned with the whole of history rather than with one period at its end. All three Persons operate all the time, for, from history's inception to its consummation, the activity of the Trinity is progressively drawing mankind on to a higher spiritual level: history is neither static nor repetitive, but the ongoing work of the living God.⁷¹ Perhaps the core of Joachim's unique thought lies in his belief that the very innermost mystery of inter-Personal relationships in the Trinity is reflected in the working out of history. Thus, instead of a simple pattern of progress through three Persons in three stages of history, he sees complex infra-structures in history which typify what he calls the five *relationes* and seven *modi*⁷² through which he attempts to understand the inner life of the Trinity. Of these relationships the most important is the double procession of the Spirit from Father and Son which creates two parallel histories of the Spirit, one beginning with Elijah and Elisha in the first *status* and the other with St. Benedict in the second.⁷³ This concept of the Trinity as a mysterious 'society' communally active in a complexity of patterns throughout history belies the overly simple notion often attributed to Joachim of a straight lineal sequence in which three successive ages are 'appropriated' to three successive Persons, each superseding the preceding one.⁷⁴ This latter could be called a two-dimensional view, whereas Joachim's might be termed multi-dimensional. It is significant that Joachim never drew a simple horizontal figure of the three successive *status*. The figure which he created from the Wheels of Ezechiel — so often in his thoughts — shows the growth of spiritual illumination as the wheel *within* a wheel, drawing to a focus in the central caption *caritas*, the symbol of the third *status*; and the verb with which he expresses the relationship of the stages is *inesse*.

This last point leads directly to the difficult problem of Joachim's attitude towards the Second Person of the Trinity. It has sometimes been assumed

⁷¹ On Joachim's theology of history, see M. Reeves, *The Influence of Prophecy in the Later Middle Ages* (Oxford 1969) 17–21; *Figurae* 5–19. See also RTAM 21 (1954) 211–247. On the last point, see Mottu, *Manifestation* 89: 'Il n'est point exagéré de dire qu'avec Joachim, et peut-être pour la première fois dans l'histoire de l'herméneutique chrétienne, une claire prise de conscience du temps de l'Église et de son histoire se fait jour dans sa différence d'avec une conception uniforme et répétitive du temps post-christique.'

⁷² The five *relationes* are Father; Father and Son; Father, Son, and Spirit; Son and Spirit; Spirit. The seven *modi* are Father; Son; Spirit; Father and Son; Father and Spirit; Son and Spirit; Father and Son and Spirit (*Psalt.* fols. 257^v–262^v).

⁷³ For a fuller exposition, see *Figurae* 31–38, 45–51; M. Reeves, 'The Abbot Joachim's Sense of History,' in *1274: Année Charnière* 783–787.

⁷⁴ From this viewpoint I think R. Manselli, 'La Terza Età, Babylon e l'Anti-christo Mistico,' *Bullettino dell' Istituto Storico Italiano per il Medio Evo e Archivio Muratoriano* 82 (1970) 49, 58–59, presses too far the concept of 'appropriation' of the Three Persons to three separate *status* as the core of Joachim's doctrine, even though at times Joachim's language may seem to justify this view.

that in Joachim's experience and thought Christology occupied a very minor place compared with his doctrine of the Holy Spirit. This, I submit, is mistaken. His great experience of illumination came on Easter night when, at the hour when the Lion of the Tribe of Judah rose from the dead, Christ freed his mind to understand the plenitude of the Scriptures. It was this experience which sparked him off, and it preceded that other, the Whitsuntide, moment of illumination, which was centred on the Spirit. He recalls that Easter moment, not only in the *Expositio* where it is fully recorded, but also in the preface to the *Liber concordie*, where commitment to Christ is stated to be the only sure way to understanding; the work also ends on a Christological note.⁷⁵ In the *Expositio* only Christ can open the Book with Seven Seals; in the *Tractatus super quatuor evangelia*, there is a long disquisition on the *Verbum Dei*. The great *opera Christi* are repeatedly emphasized and linked with the seven Gifts of the Spirit. In Book V of the *Liber concordie*⁷⁶ Joachim expounds the four 'special' histories — Job, Tobias, Judith, Esther — which are symbolized in the four *facies* of Ezechiel's wheels and typify the four *opera Christi* as well as the four evangelists. And here, in working out the detailed symbolism of each, he always passes instinctively from their fulfillment in the earthly life of Christ to their meaning in terms of the final stage of history: the *opera Christi* are not to be superseded but will be fully realised only in the jubilation of the third *status*. In the *Psalterium* Joachim expresses the communal activity of the three Persons in terms of the five General Virtues, the five *opera Christi*, and the seven Gifts of the Spirit, stressing in a passage devoted to the simultaneity of the Trinity's working, the giving of the Gifts equally by the Second and Third Persons.⁷⁷

Joachim, we must recall, worked with a 'pattern of twos' as well as 'threes.'⁷⁸ In the introductory book to the *Expositio*, he makes the transition from one pattern to the other by stressing that the 'tempus novi testamenti' is 'geminum.'⁷⁹ — One can view this whole time as the sixth *aetas* 'et totum ascribendum est Christo,' or one can see it as the sixth and seventh, containing within it the Sabbath Age 'in regione vivorum.' In Joachim's mind it would

⁷⁵ *Expos.* fol. 39^{r-v}; *Lib. conc.*, *Prefatio* and fol. 135^v.

⁷⁶ *Lib. conc.* fols. 113^{ff}.

⁷⁷ *Psalt.* fols. 260^v–263^v. Note especially: 'Quia simul in seipsis tote tres persone habent posse dare septem spiritus qui sunt septem dona ipsius spiritus: mittunt illos in omnem terram. . . . Habent itaque aliquid simile iste quinque virtutes cum quinque relationibus istis: sicut et septem dona spiritus sancti cum septem illis modis quibus dicuntur ad se persone deitatis: sive unaqueque sigillatim: sive communiter due vel tres. Que videlicet septem donis quamvis sint verissime totius trinitatis propterea tamen specialius eidem spiritui ascribuntur . . .' (fols. 161^v–162^r).

⁷⁸ See *Figurae* 6–12.

⁷⁹ *Expos.* fol. 9^r.

seem that the 'double time' exemplifies the simultaneous working of the three Persons: 'sed quia . . . verum est quod tres persone deitatis coeterne sunt sibi et coequales, et quia simul operantur omnia et equaliter universa, oportet nos tempus testamenti novi duplex et geminum intelligere.' In a striking interpretation of the Transfiguration Joachim sees Christ, in the dazzling splendour of the sun, between Moses representing the second *status*, and Elijah the third; at the *transitus* between the two *status*, He dominates both.⁸⁰ In the double time of the New Testament Christ cannot be displaced but operates in two modes. Thus at one point Joachim suggests that the work of the Second Person in the third *status* will be embodied in a secret advent, to precede the final glorious Advent:

in tertii status seculi spiritaliter [scriptura] refundenda ac si his diebus nasceretur Christus: his diebus resuscitatus a mortuis: donum spiritus sancti insufflaret in discipulis suis: his diebus apostolos suos mitteret ad predicandum in gentibus: his iterum idem apostoli novas complantarent et supereificarent ecclesias: quod totum ut iam dixi in spiritu in exordio tertii statu consumari oportet.⁸¹

Here Joachim foreshadows the concept of the 'middle advent' of Christ used later by some Franciscans.

The different modes in which Joachim views the inner relations of Son and Spirit are strikingly brought out in the diamond-shaped *pavimentum* which he expounds in the *Liber concordie*.⁸² Here the horizontal progression through Old Testament history is plotted by the seven seals, each of which is marked by a pair of Persons typifying Son and Spirit respectively, as 'sent' by the Father. But Son and Spirit alternate between the top and bottom points of the diamonds, so that in the first the Spirit is 'preferred' above the Son, in the second the Son above the Spirit, and so on through the sequence of seven. The last pairs are 'doubled' under the sixth seal, emphasizing the equality of Persons which the whole pattern demonstrates: 'et ad ultimum in equalitate consummationem accipiunt.'⁸³

Joachim does, indeed, get into dangerous water in his use of words to describe the special association of each Person with one of the three *status*. In the succinct account of the three *status* which he gives in the introductory book to the *Expositio*⁸⁴ he uses such expressions as 'pertinere ad patrem' or 'ascribi-

⁸⁰ *Ibid.* fol. 137v.

⁸¹ *Ibid.* fol. 12r.

⁸² *Lib. conc.* fols. 26v-38r. Miss S. Zindars-Swartz first drew my attention to the significance of the *pavimentum*.

⁸³ *Ibid.* fol. 38r. In a figure of the generations one caption emphasizes this point: 'Hic ostenditur quod Filii et Spiritus Sancti una est divinitas, equalis gloria, coeterna maiestas.' See *Figurae* 37.

⁸⁴ *Expos.* fols. 5r-6r.

tur patri,' and so on. But immediately he seems to be aware of the danger in these terms. The third, he says, is the *status* pertaining to the Spirit, and yet, he adds hastily, from another viewpoint there is only one *status* of the world's history, one elect people, and all things pertain simultaneously to Father, Son, and Spirit.⁸⁵ Then, in order to show the over-lapping levels on which the three Persons operate, he starts playing with patterns, demonstrating how fluid they are. Take, for instance, the standard three: *tempus ante legem, sub lege, sub gratia*. To these, he says, you can add two more — *tempus sub spiritali intellectu* and *tempus manifeste visionis*. So then you can take the first three and ascribe them to Father, Son, and Spirit, or you can start with the second and ascribe *sub lege* to the first Person, *sub gratia* to the Second, and *sub spiritali intellectu* to the Third. And finally you can have *sub gratia* pertaining to the Father, *sub spiritali intellectu* to the Son, and *in manifeste visionis* (i.e., eternity) to the Spirit. All these different ways of viewing the work of the Trinity are given 'ita ut seipso manens integrum in nullo patiat scandalum circa mysterium unitatis.'⁸⁶ In the *Psalterium* he demonstrates a similar point by means of the five chief patriarchs: Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob can first be taken to represent the three Persons; but then the sequence can be shifted so that Isaac represents the Father and so on, while finally it can be shifted again so that the sequence becomes Jacob, Father, Joseph, Son, Ephraim, Spirit.⁸⁷ And all these different ways of viewing the Trinity are given 'ut nihil in ea prius aut posterius esse credamus: nihil maius aut minus: sed tota tres personas coeternas sibi esse et coequales.'⁸⁸

However much enthusiasm for the vision of the age to come might carry Joachim at times into extreme statements, I would take the view that the thought summarised in the preceding paragraphs indicates his basic position and his own warning against over-simplifying this mysterious work of the Trinity in history. For above the horizontal thrust of the three *status*, successive in time and in ascription to the three Persons, there appears in Joachim's system a multi-layered structure of significances in which the Persons inter-change parts or, rather, inter-penetrate each other. Joachim can simultaneously think of a life of the Spirit which will supersede earlier spiritual stages, and of a multi-dimensional Godhead which operates in all three Persons all the time and is itself a unity.

But here we reach a paradox. None of these complex and shifting patterns detracts from that horizontal thrust forward of Joachim's great prophetic affirmation of the Age of the Spirit shortly to dawn. Here he sweeps into use

⁸⁵ *Ibid.* fol. 5v.

⁸⁶ *Ibid.*

⁸⁷ *Psalt.* fol. 269r.

⁸⁸ *Expos.* fol. 5v.

all possible figures: the Sabbath or Seventh Age of history, the silence of the seventh-seal opening in the Church's history, the thousand-year figure of Satan bound, the descent of New Jerusalem, the space after Antichrist. All these are used for the elaboration of his great concept of the climax ahead, the climax to the whole process of history and the work of the whole Trinity. Joachim's most original thought may be said to be contained in his mystical vision of the Trinity as a society of Persons at work in all ages and in all events of time, but his greatest impact was made by his delineation of the last earthly stage of that progressive illumination which is the purpose of God in history.⁸⁹

The crucial point here is that — however mystically conceived — it is still a new stage of *history* which he envisages. It is not a supernatural millennium coming down from above; it is not just a 'pause' granted by God rather arbitrarily. It is the logical climax of the whole historical process, but because it is still part of time it does not embody final perfection. A new experience will be given, and men will live on a higher plane of spiritual understanding, but Joachim never confuses this with the illumination of eternity in the full presence of God. The tribulation of Antichrist in the Sixth Age is to be greater than but not different from those inflicted by the sequence of tyrants throughout the Church's history. The agents of his overthrow are seen in the main as human, though divinely aided. Because the third *status* is still part of history, even its life must at the last deteriorate and a final persecution of Antichrist under the form of Gog and Magog must ensue.⁹⁰ Joachim never confuses the Seventh Day with the Eighth Day of eternity.

Those of us among twentieth-century scholars who have made a study of Joachim of Fiore have perhaps given too much attention to the debate on whether he was orthodox or heterodox, conservative or radical, even revolutionary. The first category, as Professor McGinn points out, is not really

⁸⁹ In a recent, profoundly thoughtful essay, 'Il problema del doppio Anticristo in Gioacchino da Fiore' in *Geschichtsschreibung und geistiges Leben im Mittelalter: Festschrift für Heinz Löwe zum 65. Geburtstag*, edd. K. Hauck and H. Mordek (Cologne and Vienna 1978) 427–449, Professor Manselli makes the point that 'il vero e proprio Anticristo' comes at the end of the third *status* under the name of Gog. From this he draws the conclusion that the third *status* is not 'un terzo momento della storia' so much as 'il momento iniziale dell'età escatologica,' preparing for the final Antichrist and Last Judgement. This needs further consideration, but — leaving aside the question of whether the 'greatest Antichrist' comes before or at the end of the third *status* — the positive promise of the Sabbath Age as a stage of history which will mark fresh achievement after triumph over the greatest Antichrist to appear so far seems to me to come through in innumerable passages, although, of course, it is always a *transitus* to the Eighth Day of eternity.

⁹⁰ See *Figurae* 125–126, 165–168; Reeves, *Influence*, 132, 303, 305; *Lib. conc.* fols. 52r, 56r-v; *Expos.* fols. 9r–11r, 24v, 207r, 212r–214r. See also Lerner, 'Refreshment of the Saints' 119.

useful today, since it is so relative and value-laden.⁹¹ But the others, too, contain many ambiguities. 'Radical' and 'revolutionary' are not interchangeable etymologically. Joachim was radical in the original sense of the word, that is, desiring to go back to fundamental roots; he was not, I think, revolutionary in the sense of desiring to turn the institutions of the Church right round. McGinn uses the word 'radical' to signify 'a type of relation between thought and its institutional and social context in which the implementation of thought would effect drastic change in the mode of institutional operation.'⁹² This seems to be another way of describing qualitative change rather than the overturning of authority. In this sense also I should agree that Joachim was 'radical.' 'Revolutionary' goes much further: it implies the supersession of old authorities by new, and the contention of Dr. Mottu, in his recent book, is that Joachim, in his latest work, the *Tractatus super quatuor evangelia*, goes to the point of prophesying that the *ecclesia spiritualis* will embody a new authority replacing the old.⁹³ The crucial question here is whether Joachim was consciously moving in the *Tractatus* to a more revolutionary position than that held in his main trilogy, or whether the inner logic of the typology which he was expounding insensibly carried him further than he intended. In the earlier works it still seems to me clear that institutionally the Roman Church remains unmoved in authority, although to be transformed spiritually.⁹⁴ Dr. Mottu makes a considerable point of Joachim's use in all his works of the succession of *ecclesiae* and the concept of transition from the *ecclesia secundi status* to the *ecclesia spiritualis* of the third *status*.⁹⁵ This is certainly dangerous language; yet in the main works we see that, where the context is that of transition from one to another, *ecclesia* invariably signifies the people or orders of the Church, never the institution of the Church, the mystic bride of Christ, which is the Roman Church. What is envisaged is transformation of people rather than institutional substitution.⁹⁶

⁹¹ B. McGinn, 'The Abbot and the Doctors: Scholastic Reactions to the Radical Eschatology of Joachim of Fiore,' *Church History* 40 (1971) 34. A similar point is made by D. Flood, O.F.M., 'A Study in Joachimism,' *Collectanea Franciscana* 41 (1971) 135-136.

⁹² McGinn, 'The Abbot and the Doctors' 34.

⁹³ Mottu, *Manifestation*, *passim*.

⁹⁴ See the references given in Reeves, *Influence* 395-396.

⁹⁵ Mottu, *Manifestation* 89.

⁹⁶ The problem is complicated by the fact that Joachim, of course, held that in the first *transitus* the Synagogue was literally superseded by the Church. Thus when he makes the concord with the second *transitus* it is natural to assume that he intended a similar supersession. Yet all the passages dealing with the *transitus* from the Church of the second *status* to that of the third are couched in terms of people on the move rather than a substitution of one institution for another. Thus *Lib. con.* fol. 58^{r-v}: 'Et ut populus fidelis qui egressus est de synagoga transiens per doctrinam et verbum Christi . . . receptus est in sinu matris ecclesie . . . ita nunc quoque amatores Christi transeant per doctrinam spiritualement recipien-

Does, then, the *Tractatus* go further? I cannot here do full justice to the richness of Mottu's treatment of this question, but we may look briefly at his examination of the way Joachim handles the episode in which the ancient Simeon embraces the infant Christ and pronounces his *Nunc dimittis*.⁹⁷ This, says Mottu, prefigures, according to Joachim, the old Church embracing and yielding place to the new: 'symbolisant l'institution romaine *vieillissante* accueillant la jeunesse, l'avenir, *l'enfancement* historique du *populus sanctorum*.'⁹⁸ But in this passage Joachim speaks of the *presules* of the Roman Church and the *successores Petri*, not of the 'Roman institution,' as Mottu has it: it is the people, not the offices, which must yield place. Again, when Joachim goes on to speak of *dissolutio* and *successio*,⁹⁹ he is thinking in terms of 'orders,'

di quandoque et ipsi in sinu spiritualis ecclesie.' In two passages in which Joachim uses a shifting typology (*Lib. Con.* fol. 61^r and *Psalt.* fol. 265^{r-v}) he has a series of *ecclesiae* all designated in terms of people or orders and their characteristic activities, e.g., *ecclesia secularium*, *clericorum*, *monachorum*. Again, in *Expos.* f. 83^r, where the *ecclesiae* are specifically linked to the three *status*, similar broad terms are used: *ecclesia clericorum*, *ecclesia* or *populus spiritualis* or *contemplativa*. *Ecclesia laborantium* / *contemplantium* (*Lib. conc.* fols. 85^v, 96^v), *societas contemplantis ecclesie* (*ibid.* fol. 83^v), *populus tertii status* (*ibid.* fol. 96^r), *populus sanctorum* (*ibid.* fol. 69^v) — these and similar expressions occur many times. In none of the passages just cited is the *ecclesia romana* or *ecclesia Petri* associated with this concept of successive churches: the context in which Joachim uses these terms is, in general, quite different; the *ecclesia romana* or New Jerusalem remains immoveable. Yet sometimes immutability and transition are brought together: 'Non igitur . . . deficit ecclesia Petri que est thronus Christi . . . sed commutata in maiorem gloriam manebit stabilis in eternum' (*Lib. con.* fol. 95^v). David, first reigning in Hebron, then in Jersalem, typifies the Papacy: 'Quia occurrit pontificibus romanis preesse ecclesie laborantium; postea ecclesie quiescentium, prius desudantium in vita activa: postea exultantium in vita contemplativa' (*ibid.* fol. 92^v). In one of the 'special histories' treated as typifying the transition to the third *status*, at the end of the *Lib. con.*, a convincing link between the new life to come and the Church of Peter is made: Queen Esther typifies both the *vita contemplativa* and the Roman Church which Christ 'prefers' above all others, whilst her parent, Mordecai, represents Peter. Thus, in the final apotheosis after the storm of Antichrist, Mordecai's exaltation is that of Peter's successor 'qui erit in tempore illo quasi fidelissimus vicarius Christi iesu elevabitur in sublime' (*Lib. conc.* fol. 122^v).

⁹⁷ *Tractatus super quatuor evangelia*, ed. E. Buonaiuti (Rome 1930) 86: 'itaque senex iste iustus et timoratus Romane presules designat Ecclesie . . . et cum dabitur ei videre quod optat, ut videlicet ita videat confirmatum donum Spiritus sancti in populo christiano, sicut futurum credimus in adventu Helie, qui venturus est omnia consummare, videns sanctum illum ordinem quem Ecclesia peperit spiritalis. . . . accipiet eum in ulnas fidei et dilectionis sue et pronuntiabit in eo esse illum vivificantem Spiritum. . . .'

⁹⁸ Mottu, *Manifestation* 137.

⁹⁹ *Tractatus* 87: 'quasi ergo in ulnas suas suscipiet puerum senex Symeon, cum successores Petri quibus data est prerogativa fidei et discernere inter sanctum et prophanum, videntes illum ordinem qui imitatur vestigia Christi, in virtute spiritali, sustentabit eum munimine auctoritatis sue et confirmabit verbis testimonii sui, annuncians complenda esse in ipso ticia prophetarum. . . . neque enim super dissolutionem suam poterit dolere, cum se in

as in the many passages in which he expounds the 'order' or 'religion' or 'life' of Peter compared with that of John;¹⁰⁰ and *ordo* for Joachim always seems to mean a type of religious life lived by a body of people rather than a formally constituted institution. There is, indeed, one ambiguous statement in the *Tractatus* on the transitory nature of the sacraments¹⁰¹ but Joachim's meaning here is obscure, and I do not think this can stand against the weight of what seems to me to be Joachim's general position: that the *una ecclesia* is unchanging in truth and authority, but the history of the Church has been and will be the developing work of the creative Spirit, seen in terms of successive orders. In his exposition of the Simeon figure Joachim emphasizes that 'Peter' will not mourn but rejoice over the perfection of the succeeding order which will be one with him in spirit and doctrine. In the *Liber figurarum* any harsh suggestion conveyed by the concept of *dissolutio/successio* is still further transcended in the 'Dispositio novi ordinis pertinens ad tercium statum,' where the orders of the first two *status* are actually subsumed into that of the third *status* and at the centre is the *Sedes Dei*, the *sancta Jerusalem*, which is the Roman Church.¹⁰²

Again, Dr. Mottu reads Joachim's exposition of the water turned into wine at the marriage of Cana in a similar sense:¹⁰³ as once Christ effected the miracle, so the Spirit will transform the vain *scientia litterae* into the *intellectus spiritualis* in the new age, and Mottu draws the deduction that Christ has been reduced to the 'type,' the promise of that which is to come. 'En effet ce n'est plus le Christ qui est, à proprement parler, le sujet d'une telle transformation, mais l'Esprit.'¹⁰⁴ The marriage of Cana, he concludes, has become for Joachim the type, not only of the conversion of Letter into Spirit, but of the structural and institutional transformation of the Church of Christ into 'una nova religiosorum Ecclesia.'¹⁰⁵ This appears at first to be a convincing and logical conclusion

melliori successione permanere cognosceret. scimus enim quod ut alius ordo designetur in precesore, alius in successore, non facit diversitas fidei, set proprietas religionis.'

¹⁰⁰ E.g., *Lib. con.* fols. 18^r, 58^r; *Expos.* fols. 17^r-18^v, 22^r-23^v, 49^v-50^v, 137^v, 141^vff.; *Psalt.* fol. 265^v. Even when, in *Expos.* fol. 204^v, he speaks of the two *ecclesiae* of Peter and John, these still represent types of order (*predicantium* and *contemplantium*), not the Roman Church and a successor.

¹⁰¹ *Tractatus* 86: 'set quare vel a Domino dicitur evangelium Regni, vel a Iohanne evangelium eternum, nisi quia illud quod mandatum est nobis a Christo vel apostolis, secundum fidem sacramentorum, quantum ad ipsa sacramenta transitorium est et temporale, quod autem per ea sacrificatur, eternum?'

¹⁰² *Lib. fig.* plate 12. See *Figurae* 232-248.

¹⁰³ *Tractatus* 191-202; Mottu, *Manifestation* 180-186.

¹⁰⁴ Mottu, *Manifestation* 184.

¹⁰⁵ *Ibid.* But notice that the passage which Mottu here quotes (*Tractatus* 193) couches the transformation in terms of a 'nova religiosorum Ecclesia' which hardly justifies his interpretation as an institutional, structural conversion of the Church.

to draw from Joachim's text, and yet there is a basic absurdity about it. The power of Christ, as we have seen, was central to Joachim's experience of the breakthrough from Letter to Spirit. It was He who rolled away the stone from the mind to release the spiritual understanding. Again and again the role of Christ as the key to the Scriptures is emphasized, and Joachim, it must be remembered, saw Biblical exegesis as the key to the future.

In short, I would hold that in his doctrine of the Trinity Joachim is firm on the equality and co-eternal nature of the Persons: they inter-penetrate, but do not succeed each other. This gives a multi-dimensional texture to history which can be interpreted simultaneously on differing levels. Yet almost running counter to this was Joachim's tremendous sense of that progressive evolution ('de claritate in claritatem'¹⁰⁶) through time which would bring men ultimately to the manifest vision of God. In pinning the three successive stages of mankind's pilgrimage to the separate Persons of the Trinity, Joachim gave a powerful prophetic thrust to hope, but endangered the fullness of his own Trinitarian doctrine. It was because Joachim's Age of the Spirit was an Age of History, albeit only vaguely seen in terms of dates, that his vision caught on in such varied ways. For many the emphasis came to be placed on this affirmation of a further turning-point in time, either already present or approaching, a moment to usher in a final and blessed epoch of history. This countered triumphantly the dispiriting view that the one great climax of history was past and little was left now but waiting. Thus it came about that — almost ironically — Joachim's most original thought on the Trinitarian structure of history, even the most famous part of it, the three Persons linked to the three *status*, could be lost, while his affirmation of a second turning-point just ahead and a blessed time yet to be expected within history became his most powerful and distinctive gift to future generations.

III

What constitutes a Joachite or justifies the claim of Joachimist influence?¹⁰⁷ Clearly we can dismiss at once not only writers who give a formal notice to

¹⁰⁶ This and similar phrases are used by Joachim a number of times. See *Lib. conc.* fol. 112r; *Expos.* fols. 5v, 45r, 78r, 86r; *Tractatus* 21, 74.

¹⁰⁷ 'Joachite,' 'Joachimist,' 'Joachist,' and other varieties have been freely used according to taste. McGinn, 'The Abbot and the Doctors' 35, gives his own definition of the terms 'Joachite,' 'Joachimist.' I have preferred to stick to Salimbene's use of 'Joachita' (Eng. 'Joachite') as a name for one who is a disciple or committed to Joachim's Trinitarian doctrine of history. 'Joachimist' then becomes the broader adjective describing varying degrees of influence on ideas or writings. J. Paul, 'Le Joachimisme et les Joachimites au milieu de XIII^e siècle, d'après le témoignage de Fra Salimbene,' 1274: *Année charnière* 799,

Joachim but even in many cases those who, in giving him a notice, manifest a positive interest in him. In the thirteenth and following centuries, Joachim received many such notices, for his reputation was considerable. This reputation was based on a standard set of stories, some containing truth, some apocryphal. He was known as the prophet of Antichrist, the interpreter of the seven-headed dragon, the oracle on the fate of Jerusalem, the recipient of a miraculous gift of spiritual understanding, the prophet of the two great mendicant orders, and the proclaimer of 1260 as the year of crisis. In noting these, writers were usually just repeating what everybody knew about the Abbot Joachim. Prophets were news and got good notices, but the essence of Joachimism lay, not in isolated prophecies, but in the imminent consummation of a whole theology of history in its last two stages of the greatest tribulation in time and the final spiritual flowering of history. A Joachite must be one who views the future from this historical perspective; the evidence of 'Joachimist influence' must include, not just belief in Joachim as a prophet, but an expectation that history must be fulfilled in a coming age of illumination.¹⁰⁸ Here I am leaving aside a few examples of probable Joachimist influence in aspects of thought other than those directly connected with his theology of history.¹⁰⁹

The most difficult problem in arriving at one's criteria for applying the terms 'Joachite,' 'Joachimist' is whether one restricts them to cases in which there was an explicit affirmation of Joachim's Trinitarian structure of the three *status*. This, as we have seen, is fundamental to his belief in the future age of blessedness and therefore it would seem logical to apply this principle rigidly. In that case a great deal which has been called Joachimist must be swept aside. There are, however, many examples in which a future turning-point of history and an age of beatitude within time are affirmed without reference to the three *status*. If I have justly summed up the state of thought concerning the end of history just prior to Joachim's appearance, there was no clear affirmation of such a turning-point and new *status* within history, although there are hints that expectations were working towards this. If Joachim's thought was the catalyst which precipitated this full expectation, we can fairly claim 'Joachimist influence' in a number of thirteenth-century Franciscans, for instance, while reserving the term 'Joachite' for the full

points out that Salimbene's use is peculiar and that he turns an adjective into a noun. See also Father Brady's discussion of what constitutes a 'Joachite' in his review of my book in *Catholic Historical Review* 58 (1972-1973) 612.

¹⁰⁸ The complaints of several reviewers of *Influence* underline the need to use clear criteria in applying these terms; see, for example, Father Brady, *ibid*.

¹⁰⁹ See, for example, Werner of Rochefort and Opicinus de Canistris. For these, see *Figurae* 297-299.

disciples of his Trinitarian doctrine of history. But the possibility remains that some of these thirteenth-century thinkers were drawing on the general trends of contemporary thought rather than on the specifically Joachimist vision.¹¹⁰

Turning now to actual examples, we have, of course, one clear thirteenth-century case of a Joachite in Gerard of Borgo San Donnino, who specifically based his *Eternal Evangel* on Joachim's system, as embodied in his writings, and was recognised as doing so by the Commission of Anagni, which condemned his views.¹¹¹ Much more problematic are the two for whom Salimbene appears to have invented the word Joachite when he called them 'maximi Iohachite.'¹¹² What did he mean? There is no exposition of Joachim's full doctrine either in Hugh de Digne's surviving writings or in Salimbene's reporting of conversations at Hyères, where Joachim is cited frequently but only on particular prophecies. Thus, so far as our evidence goes, Hugh does not appear as a real Joachite. Whilst the implication of John of Parma in Gerard's fall suggests strongly that he belonged to a Joachimist school of thought, again, the evidence we have does not prove him a full Joachite. Salimbene himself constitutes a further doubtful case. He does indeed give a brief, clear statement of Joachim's doctrine of the three *status*,¹¹³ but can we claim that his frequent references to Joachim constitute more than an onlooker's interest? To do so one must show that his *Cronica* was written from a Joachimist perspective. Professor Delno West sets out to do just this,¹¹⁴ arguing from Salimbene's selection of material and particular emphases that he read events in Joachimist terms, believing himself to be living in the transition period between the second and third *status*. West points to four dominant themes in the *Cronica* which, he argues, are expressions of Joachimism: the eschatological role of St. Francis and the Minorites, the presence of the Whore of Babylon in the Church, the manifestations of Antichrist, including Frederick II, and the period of cosmic tribulation into which he believed the world had already plunged. The difficulty is

¹¹⁰ An example of a superficial Joachimist influence can be found in D. Solomon's study 'The Sentence Commentary of Richard Fishacre and the Apocalypse Commentary of Hugh of St. Cher,' *Archivum Fratrum Praedicatorum* 46 (1976) 367–377, in which he shows that Hugh could use Joachim's *Expositio in Apocalypsim* without adopting his expectation of a coming Age of the Spirit.

¹¹¹ For this episode, see references in Reeves, *Influence* 59–66; see also M.-M. Dufeil, 1274: *Année charnière* 816–819.

¹¹² Salimbene, *Chronica*, MGH SS 32.232.

¹¹³ *Ibid.* 466.

¹¹⁴ D. West, 'Between Flesh and Spirit: Joachite Pattern and Meaning in the *Cronica* of Fra Salimbene,' *Journal of Medieval History* 3 (1977) 339–352. See also Paul, 'Le Joachimisme et Les Joachimites' 797–813, who sees Salimbene's Joachimism as something already dead before he wrote his *Cronica*.

that all these are fairly common themes arising out of the general mood of expectation that *in istis novissimis diebus* signs, portents, and miracles would mark the approach of Last Things. But, as West shows, again and again Salimbene connects these portents with Joachim's utterances and, although as yet he sees no evidence of a dawning third *status*, in at least one passage he hopes for the vision of the new society expressed in Joachim's figure of the 'Dispositio novi Ordinis in tercium statum.'¹¹⁵ It seems that Salimbene does wear Joachimist spectacles to interpret his world, even if he is not committed to a full Joachimism.

The eschatological role of St. Francis raises a crucial example, for this concept was so widely held, and by Church leaders who were otherwise so far from being Joachites, that we have to consider alternative sources for the Franciscans' sense of their crucial mission in these latest days. Professor Daniel argues that the Franciscan concept of their role stems from 'an eschatology of renewal' and that this 'distinguishes the Franciscan concept of mission sharply from the Joachite doctrine.'¹¹⁶ He contrasts Joachim's sense of progression towards a further stage of spirituality with the reformist aspiration to return to an original, now lost, apostolic perfection. Furthermore, he thinks this desire for renewal received its urgency from the Augustinian understanding of history as slipping down through deterioration to its end. In these last days, therefore, St. Francis and his disciples saw their task as showing men and women how to prepare for the Last Judgement. This sense that the crisis of history was approaching seems to spring naturally out of the general twelfth-century mood but it does not necessarily lead to belief in a Joachimist turning-point, that is, a climax of achievement within time before the end.

But in this eschatology the crucial symbol for St. Francis is that of the Sixth Angel of the Apocalypse.¹¹⁷ Now, I believe it is significant that the first to claim this role for St. Francis were, apparently, those two associated with Joachimism, John of Parma and Gerard of Borgo San Donnino. The Sixth Angel is indeed the precursor of Last Things, sealing the faithful who will make the *transitus* to the Seventh, the Sabbath, Age. But Joachim saw this crucial *transitus* from the sixth to the seventh *aetas* as taking place *in this world* and he interpreted the Sixth Angel as a symbol of the *virī spirituales* to be sent by God to lead the faithful into the third *status*. If it was Joachim's prophecy which originally led to this identification of St. Francis, it is also the case that when it was adopted by Bonaventure and many others it need not have carried this connotation. There is in fact an ambiguity in this role according to where

¹¹⁵ Salimbene, MGH SS 32.293.

¹¹⁶ E. R. Daniel, *The Franciscan Concept of Mission in the High Middle Ages* (Lexington, Ky. 1975) 27 and *passim* for the later part played by 'Joachites' in the Order.

¹¹⁷ For references, see Reeves, *Influence* 176, nn. 3, 4, 5.

the *transitus* is placed: if it is from the final crisis of tribulation in this world to a Sabbath in the next, then the eschatological role of St. Francis can be viewed as belonging to the Augustinian tradition; if the *transitus* is expected as the passage across Jordan into a Promised Land of further beatitude within history, then St. Francis as the Sixth Angel carries a Joachimist significance.

The key person here and the most enigmatic in our context is St. Bonaventure. On the one hand, he takes over the identification of St. Francis as the Angel of the sixth seal; on the other, the duty of suppressing the extreme Joachimism of Gerard was laid upon him. On the one hand, in his only direct reference to Joachim he dismissed him as ignorant and *simplex*;¹¹⁸ on the other, as Dr. Joseph Ratzinger has shown in his magisterial study,¹¹⁹ Bonaventure's latest sermons, collected in the *Hexaemeron*, show a definite break with the traditional Augustinian interpretation of history and the development of a new theology of history which finds its closest affinities with Joachim's. In view of the problems which he faced, we should not expect him to draw openly on Joachim's writings or to adopt a full Trinitarian Joachimism expressed in terms of the three *status*. But this means that we have no direct proof that Bonaventure had read the works of Joachim. The question, then, is whether his vision of the future should be seen in terms of Randolph Daniel's 'eschatology of renewal' or as an original form of Joachimism. Ratzinger shows that in the *Hexaemeron* Bonaventure develops his 'theoriae seminales' to prove that the clues to the meaning of future time are to be sought in the Scriptures and that, through the pattern of double sevens, a periodisation of Church history — paralleling Old Testament history — can be worked out which carries salvation history forward into a future and final stage of peace before the end of time. Christ Incarnate is seen rather as the centre of time than its 'end.' The closeness of Bonaventure's vision to Joachim's needs no elaboration. Moreover, the implication of a second turning-point in history is present in the special position accorded to St. Francis. Yet a nagging doubt remains as to Bonaventure's direct debt to Joachim. Joachim approached the future meaning of the Scriptures by a different route — through his Trinitarian doctrine, which enabled him to extrapolate the pattern of history into the third *status*. As for the double sevens, as we have seen,¹²⁰ other twelfth-century writers were moving towards a periodisation of Church history which led naturally to the idea of progressive stages. But only Joachim had placed the seventh

¹¹⁸ *Commentaria in quatuor libros sententiarum Mag. P. Lombardi, Opera omnia* I (ed. Quaracchi) 121.

¹¹⁹ J. Ratzinger, *Bonaventura* (Munich and Zurich 1959) 16–96, 106–120; tr. Z. Hayes, *The Theology of History in St. Bonaventure* (Chicago 1972) 7–24, 30–49, 82–93, 105–117. See also Reeves, *Influence* 179–181; McGinn, 'The Abbot and the Doctors' 41–45. The *Collationes in Hexaemeron* are the notes of university sermons given in Paris in 1273.

¹²⁰ See above, pp. 282–85

age of the Church decisively within history, and since Bonaventure seems clearly to be envisaging a final stage in salvation history, a further spiritual illumination within history, in this respect he seems to be a Joachite. But how consciously? Can we be certain with McGinn that he 'displays an original re-thinking of the Joachite tradition'?¹²¹ Joachimism would seem to be Bonaventure's source, but he is wary of its Trinitarian implications, drawing back from the concept of an Age of the Spirit lest it destroy the central position of Christ in history. He also displays great realism over the expectation of the final Seraphic Order which he will not identify with his own order, seeing this as the cherubic order still living in the Sixth Age. In both these respects he was probably reacting against contemporary Joachimist excesses, but we should remember that Joachim himself strove to maintain a full Christology and also drew back from claiming the final position for his own order. To sum up: Bonaventure was, I believe, deeply influenced by the 'progressive' vision of the future which had been crystallised in the thought of Joachim and had become a pervasive influence in the thirteenth century, but I do not think we can be certain that, in his doctrine of history, he was a conscious adaptor of the Joachimist expectation.

I have argued that Joachim's most important original contribution to future thought lay in his affirmation of a second turning-point in history, expected shortly or already realised. When, therefore, we meet among Franciscans the concept of three advents, that is, a 'middle advent' of Christ, interposed between the First and Final Advents, we encounter, I suggest, an adaptation of Joachimism by a Christologically oriented group. The 'pattern of threes' may be explicit or only implicit, but a crucial significance is given to the work which must be accomplished at this crisis in time between the two recognised advents, while its agent stands in concord with the Incarnate Christ. This concept of Christ's three advents, in the flesh, in the spirit, in judgement, is used by Petrus Johannis Olivi and Ubertino da Casale¹²² when they place St. Francis in the relationship to the third stage of history which Christ, at His first advent, had borne to the second stage. Here, it seems to me, Bonaventure's influence mingles with a more direct legacy from Joachim. Both Olivi and Ubertino (who copies Olivi in his fifth book) quote Joachim's genuine writings extensively and both explicitly use the concept of the three *status*. In essentials their doctrine of history was, I submit, Joachimist, and when Olivi's Scriptural commentaries have been fully studied, there may be more to say about the

¹²¹ McGinn, 'The Abbot and the Doctors.' My original statement that 'St. Bonaventura was a Joachite *malgré lui*' (*Influence* 181) does not go far enough for McGinn, but goes too far for Father Brady (see above n. 107).

¹²² See, for instance, Olivi, *Postilla super Apocalypsim*, MS Rome, Bibl. Angelica 383 fols. 7v-8r; Ubertino da Casale, *Arbor vitae crucifixae* (Venice 1485) fol. 205r.

Joachimist character of his doctrine of spiritual understanding.¹²³ But Dr. Manselli argues against this view that Olivi did not embrace Joachim's Trinitarian structure of history, that therefore he did not conceive of the three successive epochs as 'appropriated' specifically to separate Persons, and that his Christocentric position distinguishes him in a profound sense from Joachim.¹²⁴ I have already suggested that neither the appropriation of Persons to separate *status* nor the supersession of the Second Person by the Third should be taken to logical extremes in interpreting Joachim's thought.¹²⁵ Olivi had too original a mind to take over, lock, stock, and barrel, any theory of history, but it is clear that he accorded the *revelatio* of the Abbot Joachim a special position at the beginning of the sixth age of the Church, which is the moment at which, in his own scheme, the new turning-point in history occurs. Professor Burr has set out with great clarity Olivi's pattern of history and from the evidence which he cites it seems obvious that, whatever differences appear in emphases, his over-riding concept is the Joachimist expectation of a third manifestation of further spiritual illumination in the sixth and seventh *status* of the Church.¹²⁶ This belief unites him with Joachim, whether the 'agent' be seen as Christ in His second or 'middle' advent, or as the Holy Spirit. But Olivi's — and by implication Ubertino's — is a Joachimism much modified by their Franciscan outlook, with its emphasis on Christ, the lord of all history,

¹²³ This has been suggested to me by Mrs. C. Davies who has been working on Olivi's scriptural commentaries. See also D. Burr, 'The Persecution of Peter Olivi,' *Transactions of the American Philosophical Society* n.s. 66 (1976) 35.

¹²⁴ Manselli, 'La Terza Età' 48–52. In the essay 'Giovanni XXII e il Gioachimismo di Pietro di Giovanni Olivi,' *Buletino dell' Istituto Storico Italiano per il Medio Evo e Archivio Muratoriano* 82 (1970), Dr. E. Pásztor argues that Pope John XXII exaggerated Olivi's Joachimism in the four articles which he extracted from the *Postilla*. It is not possible here to do justice to her searching analysis. I can only make the points (a) that I do not believe Joachim's third *status* implied a static and final state of perfection (cf. p. 88); (b) that, in my view, Joachim, as well as Olivi, strove to preserve the perennial reality of the Church (cf. p. 88); (c) that I do not see the Trinitarian periodisation which Olivi seems to derive from Joachim as a contradiction of the centrality of Christ in history (cf. pp. 90, 105). In the end her conclusion does not seem far from mine: 'sembra indubbio che Olivi avesse previsto una terza età prima della fine dei tempi. Sotto quest' aspetto la sua visione eschatologica è senza dubbio gioachimitica' (p. 109).

¹²⁵ See above, pp. 289–92. It is significant that even Salimbene grasped something of the complexity of Joachim's thought, for in the statement on Joachim's doctrine of the three *status* cited above (see reference in n. 113), he says: '... doctrina Ioachim abbatis, qui dividit mundum in triplicem statum. Nam in primo statu seculi proprietate misterii operatus est pater in patriarchis et filiis prophetarum, *quamquam indivisibilia sunt opera trinitatis* ...' (emphasis added).

¹²⁶ Burr, 'Persecution of Peter Olivi' 17–22, 34–35, gives an impressive number of references to Olivi's unpublished works.

the Christ-role of St. Francis at the inception of the third *status*, and the peculiar importance of poverty as the way of spiritual illumination.¹²⁷

What shall we conclude about the Franciscan sense of mission in general? Daniel has shown that this could be eschatological without being Joachimist. I would add that where the 'middle advent' concept is implied by the application of Scriptural roles and words concerning Christ to St. Francis, Joachimist influence is present. For in the previous renewal movements of the twelfth century apostolic models had been claimed but not, I think, a Christ-role, which is verily a new manifestation of Christ. We may see Joachimism among thirteenth-century Franciscans as an influence sharpening their perspective on the eschatological role of St. Francis and shaping their expectation of a *transitus* into a new spiritual state in which poverty will be the key quality. But the growing view that there was no 'Spiritual' party as such characterised by a more conscious Joachimism, carries conviction.

By contrast, in the fourteenth century this pervasive influence does work its way out in groups who were differentiated with increasing sharpness from the main body of the Order by their more pronounced and radical Joachimism. Whatever Olivi's own position, he was hailed as a prophet by groups loosely termed Beguin who developed in their own way the doctrine of a third *status*. Where Bonaventure and his disciples drew back from any claim to have made the *transitus* themselves, these more fanatical groups began to see themselves as the saving remnant which had already moved into the new age — the *ecclesia spiritualis* in a new sense.¹²⁸ In Italy various Fraticelli groups made the same kind of emphases and were forced into separation by the persecution of the Church.¹²⁹ I should designate these groups as Joachimist (though often compounded with other elements), because they believed they represented that further stage of illumination which was to precede the end. A group which arrogated to itself the role of those who had made the *transitus* and were the new *ecclesia spiritualis* was drawing a logical, if extreme, conclusion from Joachim's doctrine. Other groups, such as the Apostolic Brethren and the *Guglielmiti*, though not directly relating themselves to Joachim, represent the same position of claiming to be the separated new church to whom the future belonged.

¹²⁷ See Flood, 'Study in Joachimism' 136–140. Professor Charles Davis' forthcoming article on 'Poverty and Eschatology in the *Commedia*' explores the significance of poverty in the Last Age.

¹²⁸ See Reeves, *Influence* 203–207. P. van Limborch, *Historia Inquisitionis, cui subjungitur Liber Sententiarum Inquisitionis Tholosanae 1307–1323* (Amsterdam 1692) gives many examples. See also R. Manselli, *Spirituali e Beghini in Provenza* (Studi Storici 31–34; Rome 1959) 179–254.

¹²⁹ See references and quotations in Reeves, *Influence* 212–216.

The great wave of the Flagellant Movement which swept Western Europe in 1260 has frequently been ascribed to Joachimism.¹³⁰ Here is a case in which one circumstance suggests a connection, but no other feature supports it. The circumstance is, of course, the date, one which could be derived from Joachim's writings as a crucial moment at the beginning of the *transitus* and which was certainly treated by some thirteenth-century Joachites as such. Contemporary chroniclers found the Flagellant Movement a mysterious and puzzling phenomenon with no obvious origins, so that it is tempting to make the connection. Yet the religious devotion of this movement appears to have been focused on the Virgin and on the Passion of Christ rather than on the Third Person of the Trinity, while it was the wrath and judgement of God which was expected, not the Age of the Spirit. It seems hardly likely that the date-connection was merely coincidental, yet the movement itself surely sprang out of the general sense of imminent crisis in these last days of the *saeculum* rather than out of any direct Joachimist teaching. I should therefore not wish to describe this as a Joachimist movement at all,¹³¹ whilst noting the residual connection which perhaps pinpoints the circulation of little so-called 'Joachimist' prophetic verses and other texts divorced from their original context.¹³²

We must now consider the problem of Joachimist influence from a different angle — that of two prophetic images which were widely current in the later Middle Ages and Renaissance period. The problem is the extent to which they were created or modified by the Joachimist doctrine. It has been claimed that the idea of the Angelic Pope has its roots in a passage written by the twelfth-century Gerhoh of Reichersberg, but this resolves itself into a prophetic claim that the Pope will be recognised as *orbis terrarum rectorque regnorum*, without carrying any implications of a semi-mystical figure who embodies the coming new *status*.¹³³ The idea of the Angelic Pope does not even occur specifically in Joachim's writings but the concept of a coming spiritual church leader does.¹³⁴ I should argue that the image of the Angelic Pope appears as

¹³⁰ References are given in *ibid.* 54–55, and (more up-to-date) by J. Henderson, 'The Flagellant Movement and Flagellant Confraternities in Central Italy, 1260–1400,' *Studies in Church History* XV, ed. D. Baker (Oxford 1978) 147–160.

¹³¹ Nor had I intended to describe it as such in my book; but see B. McGinn, 'Apocalypticism in the Middle Ages. An Historiographical Sketch,' *Medieval Studies* 37 (1975) 277, who thinks I was imputing 'Joachite motives' to the movement.

¹³² See the short prophecies and verses quoted in Reeves, *Influence* 49–51.

¹³³ MGH SS *Libelli de lite* 3.509–510. See B. Töpfer, *Das kommende Reich des Friedens* (Berlin 1964) 30–31; B. McGinn, 'Angel Pope and Papal Antichrist,' *Church History* 47 (1978) 157–158.

¹³⁴ See, for example, *Lib. conc.* fol. 56r: '... ascendet quasi novus dux de Babylone universalis sc. pontifex nove Hierusalem'; fol. 89r: '... erit tunc successio romani pontificis

an extension of Joachim's expectation for the following reasons. First, though the initial appearance of the term is mysterious and not in a clear Joachimist context — for I see no reason to call Roger Bacon a Joachite¹³⁵ — the idea is first fully adumbrated¹³⁶ in two series of prophecies in the early-fourteenth century which have a close connection with the Abbot.¹³⁷ One is actually called the *Liber de Flore* and the other, probably produced by Angelo Clareno's group, was very early attributed to Joachim. Secondly, the aim of the latter set, the *Vaticinia de summis pontificibus*, is to combine a recognition of the historical continuity and authority of the Church of Peter with a revolutionary prophecy of drastic spiritual change in the occupants of Peter's chair. God will intervene to direct where the first of the Angelic Popes is concealed but he will mount the historic throne. This position on the delicate question of authority corresponds closely to Joachim's attempt to maintain the continuity of the Latin Church while prophesying a drastic *transitus* to a new spiritual church. The figure of the Angelic Pope (or Popes) appears in many places in the following centuries, with or without an explicit Joachimist connection. It seems a fair conclusion that it was the Joachimist expectation which pointed up this hope and gave it its common form and that its wide dissemination bears witness to the pervasiveness of this influence, even when unacknowledged.

The other case is more problematic for, as we have seen, the expectation of a Last World Emperor goes back to the seventh century. In the thirteenth century a political Joachimism can be seen developing, primarily in the pseudo-Joachimist works which sought to identify the political figures of evil. But there were also prophetic verses and oracles which assigned a more positive role to a great political leader and, in particular, those which focused on the Hohenstaufen. One cannot claim with certainty, however, that Joachimist influences were reshaping the old Last World Emperor prophecy until in the early-fourteenth century we reach the evidence of the *Liber de Flore* — undisputably a pseudo-Joachimist work — which develops the holy partnership between Last World Emperor and Angelic Pope.¹³⁸ Instead of collapsing before the onslaught of Antichrist, the Emperor will join with the Pope after Anti-

a mari usque ad mare'; fol. 122v: '... quia successor Petri qui erit in tempore illo, quasi fidelissimus vicarius Christi Iesu elevabitur in sublime.'

¹³⁵ See Reeves, *Influence* 399.

¹³⁶ In an unpublished essay Professor D. Clarke argues that in the mid-thirteenth-century pseudo-Joachimist works *Super Hieremiam* and *Super Esaiam* the idea, though not the name, of the Angelic Pope was already emerging more clearly than I had suggested (cf. *ibid.* 397–398).

¹³⁷ These are studied in M. Reeves, 'Some Popular Prophecies from the Fourteenth to the Seventeenth Centuries' in *Popular Belief and Practice*, edd. G. J. Cuming and D. Baker (Cambridge 1972) 107–133.

¹³⁸ See H. Grundmann, 'Die Liber de Flore,' *Historisches Jahrbuch* 49 (1929) 33–91.

christ's destruction to carry out the spiritual regeneration of Christendom, defeating or converting its last enemies and recovering its centre in Jerusalem. Here is the old pseudo-Methodian programme married to the Joachimist hope, now institutionalised in these two idealised figures. This prophetic political programme is fully worked out by two fourteenth-century writers who openly trace their sources to the genuine and pseudo-writings of Joachim: Jean de Roquetaillade and Telesphorus of Cosenza.¹³⁹ Here the full political drama is played out: tribulations by evil tyrants, persecution of the true Church, schism, the calling of the true emperor and pope, their holy triumph and the era of spiritual regeneration and peace. The forms in which these two great figures of prophecy mostly appear right down to the seventeenth century were, I suggest, shaped by these two fourteenth-century Joachimites and in this sense reveal direct Joachimist influence. An important example of a prophet who preached within this context but took pains to repudiate dependence on Joachim was Savonarola. His programme of chastisement for sin, carried out by the prophesied Emperor, followed by spiritual renewal, the appearance of the Angelic Pope and the initiation of an era of beatitude in which a purified Florence would become the world spiritual leader, has a background of prophetic oracles and verses from the previous two centuries which spring out of a Joachimist soil.¹⁴⁰

When we turn to recent attempts to trace Joachimist influence in literary works we are in a very uncertain field. For instance, Professor David Jeffrey, who sees Franciscan spirituality as infusing the medieval English lyric, feels that there must be a Joachimist strand somewhere in the texture of this material.¹⁴¹ Relying a good deal on Salimbene, he starts from the point that 'notable Spiritual Franciscans espoused the Joachimist cause,' citing Hugh de Digne and John of Parma in particular, and finding a 'Joachimist flavour' in Alexander of Bremen's interpretation of the Apocalypse and the works of Brother Aymon. But the Joachimist point seems to reduce itself to the pervasive sense of urgency in *novissimis diebus* and the Franciscan sense of mission within the framework of apocalyptic expectation: 'The Order from St. Francis down through the Middle Ages was apocalyptically or Judgement oriented.' The works which Jeffrey connects with 'Joachimite methods' all possess 'an acute sense of history and the belief that the Franciscan Order

¹³⁹ See J. Bignami-Odier, *Études sur Jean de Roquetaillade* (Paris 1952); E. Donckel, 'Die Prophezeiung des Telesphorus,' *Archivum Franciscanum Historicum* 26 (1933) 29–104; Reeves, *Influence* 225–228, 321–331.

¹⁴⁰ See D. Weinstein, *Savonarola and Florence: Prophecy and Patriotism in the Renaissance* (Princeton 1970); M. Reeves, *Joachim of Fiore and the Prophetic Future* (London and New York 1976) 82–95.

¹⁴¹ D. Jeffrey, *The Early English Lyric and Franciscan Spirituality* (Lincoln, Nebr. 1975) 70–72.

stood at a particularly critical point near the end.' If, however, we accept Professor Daniel's argument that this was part of the general atmosphere and sense of mission within which Franciscans moved, we must ask for some more specifically Joachimist emphasis. Instead, Jeffrey cites another similar example in Friar John's *Meditations* and concludes that since this work 'had a profound influence on Middle English poetry it is in order that something of the shape communicated to that poetry by a "Joachimite" sense of the end of all things be fairly appreciated in its style.' But, in fact, there seems nothing distinctively Joachimist in the *Meditations*¹⁴² and Jeffrey's analysis of the poetry, interesting though it is, pinpoints nothing more specifically Joachimist.

On the other hand, a short, suggestive study of four Grail romances of the thirteenth century by Eithne M. O'Sharkey¹⁴³ opens a new field in which the signs of Joachimist influence seem more convincing, although there are no specific references to the Abbot or to his works, and we are dealing in the admittedly conjectural interpretation of symbols. All four embody the quest for perfection, of course, but they do so in the historical form of a new era within history which, I have argued, is one of the hall marks of Joachimism. All carry an emphasis on the Trinity as operating within history in successive stages. Thus the *Didot-Perceval*, drawing on the work of Robert de Boron, has three Guardians of the Grail of which the third, Perceval, inaugurates a new epoch of history in which the Grace of the Holy Spirit reigns. The same progression associated with the Trinity can be traced in the *Perlesvaus* and in *l'Estoire du Saint Graal*. Above all, Galaad in *La Quête du Saint Graal*, appears to represent the Age of the Spirit, being associated with Pentecost and clothed in flame-coloured garments which instantly recall the liturgical colour of Pentecost. 'Everything concerning him indicates that his arrival in Arthur's hall is to be interpreted as the inauguration of the Last Age of the World.'¹⁴⁴ At the climax of the romance twelve chosen knights would seem to echo the three twelves of Joachim's patriarchs, apostles, and the twelve to come in the third *status*. There are no direct links with Joachimist writings, as in the case of the Emperor and Pope symbols, so the criterion for claiming Joachimist influence here can only be the distinctive imagery of a quest leading through three successive stages, associated with the Trinity and culminating in a symbolism which clearly links the third age with the Holy Spirit.

¹⁴² *Ibid.* 71 gives as his reference G. Bondatti, *Gioacchinismo e Francescanesimo nel Dugento* (S. Maria degli Angeli 1924) 147. Bondatti refers to Oligier, *Studi francescani* 7 (1921) 143-183, and 8 (1922) 18-47, but I cannot find any positive evidence of Joachimism in the work edited by Father Oligier.

¹⁴³ E. O'Sharkey, 'The Influence of the Teachings of Joachim of Fiore on Some Thirteenth-Century French Grail Romances,' *Trivium* 2 (1967) 47-58.

¹⁴⁴ *Ibid.* 54.

The question of detecting Joachimist overtones in imagery where the connection is not explicit leads directly to the crucial case of Dante. A number of scholars have claimed to find Joachimist influence in the *Comedy*: for instance, in the prominence of the symbolism of threes, in the structure of the *Paradiso*,¹⁴⁵ in imagery taken from the *Liber figurarum*¹⁴⁶ and in the prophetic element of the *Comedy* generally.¹⁴⁷ There are, in fact, two separate aspects: the use of specific number symbolisms and imagery and the broader question of the source from which Dante derived his prophetic expectation. The simple emphasis on threes as the symbol of the Triune God is too universal a feature to prove anything specific, and I have argued elsewhere¹⁴⁸ that the structure of the *Paradiso* cannot clearly be shown to be based on Joachim's figure of the psalter with ten strings, although there are affinities. On the other hand, it can be demonstrated with near certainty, I believe, that Dante used three figures from the *Liber figurarum*.¹⁴⁹ Unless another precise source can be found, Dante was certainly using Joachimist images. Two of these concern the theology of the Trinity but the other, the pair of tree eagles, contains a hidden message of Joachim's prophetic belief in the Age of the Spirit to come.¹⁵⁰ We cannot know certainly whether Dante read this secret or simply borrowed a striking image. It is hard to believe that he would borrow without understanding. Moreover, I should take the view that Dante himself had a prophetic expectation of some kind of *renovatio* ahead in time.¹⁵¹ Apart from these three figures no one has yet detected any direct borrowings from the works of Joachim; nor did Dante's hope overtly take the form of a future Age of the Spirit, though he clearly expected not only a great new leader but also some great spiritual change in men. Dante may have drawn his hope from several sources: the Last World Emperor myth (though there is no evidence of this), the sense of crisis and climax among the Franciscans, and the more specific prophecies circulating among Joachimites. But we have no hard evidence that Joachim was a major source of inspiration.¹⁵²

¹⁴⁵ F. Ermini, *Medio Evo Latino* (Rome 1938) 319–323, argued that the order of the hierarchy in the *Paradiso* was influenced by Joachim's mounting scale in the figure of the psalter with ten strings.

¹⁴⁶ Notably by L. Tondelli, *Da Gioachino a Dante* (Turin 1944) 67–72; *Il Libro delle figure dell' abate Gioachino de Fiore* (2nd ed. Turin 1953) I 221–336.

¹⁴⁷ B. Nardi, *Dante e La Cultura Medievale* (Bari 1942) 267–270.

¹⁴⁸ *Figurae* 326–328.

¹⁴⁹ *Ibid.* 320–325.

¹⁵⁰ *Lib. fig.* plates 5, 6.

¹⁵¹ See M. Reeves, 'Dante and the Prophetic View of History' in *The World of Dante*, ed. C. Grayson (Oxford 1980) 44–60.

¹⁵² Another complex literary problem concerns the question of possible Joachimist influence in *Piers Plowman*; see M. Bloomfield, *Piers Plowman as a Fourteenth-Century Apocalypse* (New Brunswick 1961). This seemed too large a topic to include in this sketch.

Recently scholars have been turning their attention to the possible influence of Joachimist symbolism on the iconography of certain works of art. As in the case of literature the problem is to distinguish between a work which uses a specifically Joachimist idea and one which draws on a general range of images to which Joachimism may have been a contributing factor. A literary inscription, of course, can give a direct clue. Thus — to take a late example first — when Botticelli painted his mystical Nativity he inscribed above it a reference to the prophecies of Daniel which makes the prophetic context plain: 'I Sandro painted this picture at the end of the year 1500 in the troubles in Italy in the half time after the time according to the Xth chapter of St. John in the second woe of the Apocalypse in the loosing of the devil for three and a half years. Then he will be chained in the XIIth chapter and we shall see him trodden down as in this picture.' Since this time symbol of three and a half years/times was used by Joachim to indicate the period of tribulation before the ushering in of the third *status*, we have here a clear indication that the painting is a vision of the future with a Trinitarian meaning expressed in the three pairs of angels embracing men in the foreground. Following this clue Professor Weinstein has interpreted Botticelli's Crucifixion with a view of Florence in the left background in a three-fold Joachimist sense.¹⁵³ In both these pictures the design can clearly be read in a Joachimist sense, but it is the literary inscription on the first which puts this apocalyptic interpretation on a firm basis and enables us to place Botticelli within the context of the Savonarolan movement.

Lacking such evidence, we must apply the rigorous criterion of some specific and central feature or principle of organisation which seems to be peculiar to Joachimism before we can suggest Joachimist influence. An interesting case is M^{me} de Sède's interpretation of the iconographic scheme of the Sainte Chapelle.¹⁵⁴ She points out first that in a royal chapel devoted to relics of the saints there is a surprising preponderance of themes from the Old Testament treated prophetically as pointing forward to Christ. 'À son tour, l'histoire de l'Incarnation . . . contient analogiquement celle de la troisième révélation, prophétiquement annoncée par l'Apocalypse.' Once again, this is too general a feature on which to claim 'l'inspiration joachimite.' But a specific and unusual feature which has struck almost all who have studied these pictures gives us much firmer ground for postulating the influence of Joachim: 'l'importance insolite accordée aux recits de Job, Judith, Tobie et Esther.' We know both from the *Liber concordie* and from the *Liber figurarum* that these

¹⁵³ See Weinstein, *Savonarola and Florence* 336–338; Reeves, *Joachim of Fiore and the Prophetic Future* 92–93.

¹⁵⁴ S. de Sède, *La Sainte-Chapelle et la politique de la fin des temps* (Paris 1972) 203–207.

four books held a peculiar significance for Joachim.¹⁵⁵ It is often not realised that Joachim used a pattern of fours — which could develop into fives and sevens — as well as his well-known 'twos' and 'threes.' This pattern of fours was central to his Biblical exegesis and, together with that of twos, forms the structure of the figure in which he interprets the Wheels of Ezechiel. The general concordances between the two dispensations are expressed in the two big wheels — 'the wheel within a wheel' — but he draws the four *facies* of the four living creatures as four small wheels to which he assigns the four 'special histories' of the Old Testament — that is, our four books — since they mystically contain the four Gospels and the four *opera Christi* and form the transition to the second *status*. It is fundamental to Joachim's doctrine that the future indwells the past — *inesse per concordiam* — so from these concords between the Old and New Testaments springs the *spiritualis intellectus* to interpret the *opera Christi* in the third *status*. This peculiar importance given to these four histories is, I think, an original idea of Joachim's. There seems no better explanation of the prominence given to these four 'histories' in the iconography of the Sainte Chapelle than the influence of Joachim's Biblical exegesis, with its implications concerning his theology of history. But M^{me} de Sède can offer no theory as to the source from which this Joachimist feature is derived.

Again, Signora Gavazzoli finds that the sequence of scenes from the life of Abraham in the Baptistry at Parma has unusual features.¹⁵⁶ One can elucidate the meaning of an Abraham cycle in a baptistry from a number of sources 'mentre lasciano in ombra le ragioni dell' ampiezza di tale ciclo, alcune incongruenze narrative che vi si riscontrano e un più profondo legame fra la zona di Abramo e la zona del Battista.'¹⁵⁷ The emphasis on concordances points to a possible Joachimist influence but this is too common to prove anything. It is when Signora Gavazzoli is looking for an explanation of the original features of this cycle that she turns to one particular work of Joachim's, the tract *Adversus Judaeos* in which he sets out to show that God manifested Himself to the Patriarchs as Three and One and for this purpose draws largely on the life of Abraham. A peculiar emphasis is given to the visit of the three angels to Abraham. These represent the Trinity, while the episodes of Hagar and Ishmael and the Sacrifice of Isaac, in which one angel appears, symbolise the Unity of the Godhead. Signora Gavazzoli argues that the selection and position of these and other scenes, particularly the flight of Lot from Sodom, in

¹⁵⁵ *Lib. conc.* fols. 112v–122v; *Figurae* 226–228.

¹⁵⁶ M. Gavazzoli, 'Le pitture della cupola del Battistero di Parma e gli scritti di Gioacchino da Fiore,' *Il Romanico*. Atti del Seminario di studi diretto da Piero Sanpaulesi (Milan 1975) 111–144.

¹⁵⁷ *Ibid.* 114.

the Abraham cycle of the baptistery, carry the overtones of Joachim's polemic against the Synagogue. Turning then to the cycle of John the Baptist, she finds the explanation of the unusual importance given to the two disciples sent by John to Christ in Joachim's interpretation of the episode in which he sees the two disciples as the Jews and Greeks who abandon the old Mosaic faith to follow the new Church of Christ, while the two disciples who come to Christ at the tenth hour are those of the same two groups who will be converted at the end of the age. Noting that in Joachim's system of concordances the flight of Lot from Sodom is the type in the Old Testament of those who abandon the flesh for the spirit and concurs with this episode of John's disciples, she draws attention to the position in the Parma scheme of the two disciples immediately above Lot's flight from Sodom. This brief account does not do justice to the full range of Signora Gavazzoli's interpretation of details in both cycles which are illuminated by Joachim's Biblical exegesis, especially in the *Adversus Iudaeos*. There are, of course, other sources for these frescoes and she claims no certainty for this Joachimist reading of the iconography; but the theme of apologetics directed towards the Jews is not inappropriate for a baptistery, and she makes a convincing case for resolving puzzling features by reference to Joachimist texts, although there is not quite the same element of uniqueness here as in the case of the four 'histories' in the Sainte Chapelle.¹⁵⁸ But here there is little problem as to the source of influence since Parma was a likely field for Joachimism in the thirteenth century.

Another Italian art historian, Franco Prosperi,¹⁵⁹ calls attention to a particularly significant possibility that the romanesque façade of the cathedral of S. Rufino in Assisi, begun in the mid-twelfth century, should be interpreted in a Joachimist sense. He emphasizes that here the iconography is not traditional, but strikingly independent and 'personal.'¹⁶⁰ He finds the clue in two small figures in the archivolt of the central portal, one of which plays the psaltery while the other kneels before him in reverent meditation; a third meditating figure, seated within an arch, completes the little scene. Prosperi

¹⁵⁸ Signora Gavazzoli sums up thus: 'Se non unico, il testochiave tenuto presente, anche indirettamente, nella concezione dell'opera si potrebbe identificare con l'*Adversus Iudeos* di Gioacchino, poichè sia le immagini scelte, sia la loro organizzazione conducono in modo convergente verso il tema di un'apologia del Cristianesimo di fronte al credo ebraico, così come è delineata dall' abate di Fiore' (*ibid.* 139).

¹⁵⁹ F. Prosperi, *La Facciata della Cattedrale di Assisi: La Mistica Gioachimita Pre-Francescana nella Simbologia delle Sculture* (Perugia 1968).

¹⁶⁰ *Ibid.* 9: 'Nel nostro caso ogni figura ed ogni simbolo sono dettati da una personale esperienza costruttiva di un nuovo concetto mistico; non si sente la partecipazione astratta di un teologo, che detta le forme e lo scopo della immagini, ma esse sono invece il frutto vivo di una persona, che ha vissuto l'idea del motivo rappresentato e che non segue gli schemi iconografici più o meno stabiliti.'

is careful to emphasize that his interpretation of the whole does not rest solely on these figures; but his hypothesis is that these unusually graphic miniature figures are inspired by Joachim's poetical vision of the third *status* as embodied in his image of the psaltery with ten strings,¹⁶¹ and that with this key the strange iconography of the whole design can be read as a symbolic expression of Joachim's three *status*. His elucidation makes precise connections with Joachim's images and, in itself, forms a convincing scheme. But it depends on the expert 'reading' of the figures, and this constitutes the hypothetical element which, as in other cases, leaves the non-expert in the hands of the art historian.¹⁶² Accepting this interpretation obviously opens up a possible, if slender, line of connection between Joachim and St. Francis where so far none has been found.

Dr. Michael Thomas turns to Joachim's *Liber concordie* in studying the concordances drawn in the upper church at Assisi between the history of the patriarchs and the Franciscans.¹⁶³ In particular he notes the juxtaposition of Joseph and St. Francis and cites passages from Joachim on the significance of Joseph as the type of the *intellectus spiritualis* and the spiritual Order to come.¹⁶⁴ He also cites Joachim's interpretation of Esau and Jacob as the two orders of clerics and monks.¹⁶⁵ In this case, although the references to Joachim add a possible dimension to the interpretation, the case does not seem proven, since there is no clearly distinctive feature. Dr. Thomas has also,¹⁶⁶ with sharp perception, seen a possible echo of Joachim's figure, *Dispositio novi ordinis*, in the organization of the picture depicting the Dream of Joachim in the Arena Chapel at Padua. But the echo is fragmentary, and I find this interpretation somewhat far-fetched.

In most of these cases it is to Joachim's Biblical symbolism that artists appear to have turned for inspiration, and it is here that the interpreters seek for clues to unusual features. What is significant is that in none of the examples cited — with the exception of Botticelli where the peculiar crisis of Florence at that moment accounts for the apocalyptic element — is there any overt reference to Joachim's eschatology or the third *status*. I know of no illustra-

¹⁶¹ *Lib. fig.* plate 13.

¹⁶² Prosperi's interpretation of the figures is not, I think, invalidated by his imperfect knowledge of Joachim's works, but it should be noted that (a) the Perugia MS contains, not Joachim's *Liber figurarum*, but a pseudo-Joachimist figure collection (p. 12); (b) that the Commentary on Jeremiah is not Joachim's but a mid-thirteenth-century work.

¹⁶³ 'Zur Ikonographie der Franziskuslegende, besonders der Fresken Giotto's in der Oberkirche der Basilika San Francesco in Assisi,' *Zeitschrift für Religions- u. Geistesgeschichte* 28 (1976) 245-255.

¹⁶⁴ *Ibid.* 247-250.

¹⁶⁵ *Ibid.* 51-52.

¹⁶⁶ In a letter to me.

tions to the Apocalypse in this period which use Joachim's interpretations. Indeed, R. Freyhan¹⁶⁷ long ago pointed to a strikingly negative example in the English Apocalypse of the thirteenth century where the pictures are literal representations of scenes from the Apocalypse whilst a Joachimist gloss has been added later to the text. Possibly by the time such picture cycles as those in the Sainte Chapelle and at Parma were being created, the dangerously radical implications of Joachim's prophetic expectations were too well known to risk such interpretations. If so, it is striking that Joachim's typology in his 'pattern of twos' was still probably a considerable source of inspiration to artistic imaginations.

Paradoxically, the feature which is usually taken to be the best criterion of Joachim's influence — the three *status* of Father, Son, and Spirit — can sometimes be misleading. Thus W. Fraenger, in his *Millennium of Hieronymus Bosch*, claims that Bosch derived the inspiration for his triptych from Joachim's famous concept, which reached him, Fraenger thinks, via the Netherlandish Brethren of the Free Spirit.¹⁶⁸ This looks an attractive hypothesis but the more one examines it the more doubtful it appears. First, the three kingdoms, as he calls them, are not the three parts of the triptych itself: the Age of the Father he sees depicted in the watery, inchoate world on the outside leaves, with God the Father a tiny, remote figure up in the corner; while inside, that of the Son, he finds in the Garden of Eden scene of the left wing. The Age of the Spirit certainly occupies the central position, but then, on the right, creation collapses again into hell.¹⁶⁹ This is the circular movement of birth, growth, maturity, and decay so common in ancient philosophies, and the circle is again emphasized in the movement round the pool at the centre of the millennium, but it is as far removed as it can be from Joachim's lineal pattern of God's work in history. Secondly, the characteristics of the three 'kingdoms' which Fraenger sees in the picture do not really correspond to the qualities of life stressed by Joachim. A half-created earth on which the waters of fecundity are beginning to descend seems far removed from the discipline of the Law which characterised Joachim's first *status*. The Grace of the second seems oddly represented by the Son as God in the Garden of Eden before the Fall. Fraenger only specifically relates Joachim's concept of the third Age to the picture, distinguishing three Joachimist qualities of *perfectio*, *contemplatio*, and *li-*

¹⁶⁷ R. Freyhan, 'Joachim and the English Apocalypse,' *Journal of the Warburg and Courtauld Institutes* 18 (1955) 211–244.

¹⁶⁸ W. Fraenger, *The Millennium of Hieronymus Bosch* tr. E. Wilkins & E. Kaiser (London 1952).

¹⁶⁹ *Ibid.* 39. Fraenger calls Joachim Giacomo instead of Gioacchino throughout. Although he is able to link the triptych with the Brethren of the Free Spirit, any clear connection between this sect and Joachimism has never been established.

bertas.¹⁷⁰ But the first — *perfectio* — seems to me to have no warrant in Joachim's writings. The contemplation of Joachim's hermit order on the mountain top seems far removed from the celebration of Bosch's scene, whilst *libertas* is interpreted by Bosch with considerable abandon in the circular cavalcade of boys.¹⁷¹ These could be interpreted as Joachim's 'boys' succeeding the old men of the first, and the young men of the second, *status*, but that Joachim did not intend this symbol to be taken too absolutely is seen in the way in which elsewhere he turned the sequence on its head. Thirdly, Fraenger calls Joachim's system a dream, a utopia, a soap-bubble floating in mid-air which dissolves at the touch of reality.¹⁷² But utopia and prophecy are poles apart. The nature of 'reality' may be an open question; but Joachim certainly believed that his interpretation of history was no dream, but a system grounded in a study of the working of God's providence as revealed in the Scriptures. The link between Bosch's fantasy and the Biblical exegesis of the Calabrian Abbot seems to me tenuous in the extreme.

In the final analysis one has to ask whether certain fundamental concepts do not arise spontaneously in the human imagination in different periods of history, so that their reappearance marks not so much a continuing influence as a revival of something which lies far back in the human consciousness. Joachim's powerful concept of threes affords a clear case in which this problem must be raised. Leaving aside, therefore, many other examples in the Renaissance and later periods in which Joachimist influence is undoubted — to cite them would lengthen this article inordinately — I wish rather to end with three later cases in which the question remains open as to whether any Joachimist influence should be claimed. First, a seventeenth-century Puritan divine in England, William Saltmarsh, thought in terms of three Dispensations of Law, Gospel, and Spirit and believed that the present 'ministry' was on the verge of the third stage; again, William Erbery, with a similar background, thought in similar terms.¹⁷³ Yet neither of these cited Joachim at all, although other seventeenth-century writers did. Was the Joachimist current still flowing underground, or must we think in terms of the new experience of the age spontaneously bringing to the surface expectations similar to Joachim's expressed in ancient images? Secondly, it has often been pointed out that

¹⁷⁰ *Ibid.* 40–41.

¹⁷¹ *Ibid.* 42. Fraenger himself notes that these boys scarcely fit in with 'Giacomo's' idea of them as remote from all sexuality (p. 110).

¹⁷² *Ibid.* 41.

¹⁷³ See M. Reeves, 'History and Eschatology: Medieval and Early Protestant Thought in some English and Scottish writings,' *Medievalia et Humanistica* n.s. 4 (1973) 115–116.

Hegel's 'threes' are reminiscent of Joachim and, indeed, there is in his writings a statement of the three dispensations which suggests Joachimist influence:

Wir können diese Perioden als Reiche des Vaters, des Sohnes und des Geistes unterscheiden. Das Reich des Vaters ist die substantielle, ungeschiedene Masse, in blosser Veränderung, wie die Herrschaft Saturns, der seine Kinder verschlingt. Das Reich des Sohnes ist die Erscheinung Gottes nur in Beziehung auf die weltliche Existenz, auf sie als auf ein Fremdes scheinend. Das Reich des Geistes ist die Versöhnung. Es lassen sich diese Epochen auch mit den früheren Weltreichen vergleichen; insofern nämlich das germanische Reich das Reich der Totalität ist, sehen wir in demselben die bestimmte Wiederholung der früheren Epochen.¹⁷⁴

Yet, although at least three earlier philosophers, Lessing, Comte, and Schelling, had recognised Joachim as in some sense the first exponent of the doctrine of a three-stage enlightenment, Hegel gives no source and nowhere, so far as I am aware, cites Joachim at all. Finally, and most strikingly, the artist Kandinsky expressed his doctrine of inner spiritual progress in history in terms of three Trinitarian stages and, moreover, found them symbolised in the tree image, so often used by the Abbot.¹⁷⁵ Yet he appears to be ignorant of Joachim's existence. His pattern of threes may have been derived from Hegel, but how did the tree image come into his imagination? Powerful ideas and images almost seem to have a life of their own, and we cannot always neatly pigeon-hole them as expressing this or that 'influence.'

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¹⁷⁴ *Vorlesungen über die Philosophie der Weltgeschichte* (Stuttgart 1961) 472–473. I owe this reference to Dr. P. F. Fontaine of Utrecht.

¹⁷⁵ See Reeves, *Joachim of Fiore and the Prophetic Future* 172–173.